Importance of Religion

All humans identify, build and organize social relationships based on family. Their interaction with other people resulted in expansion of the society and culture. The complexity of the world around sometimes agitate and force them to explore towards the solution of that complexity and in the conquest of finding the solution, they find the route towards religion. Sometimes they seek purpose of their lives which is articulated by religion. Sometimes they make decisions and choices based upon religion and come out of confusions. Religion also provide an ethical framework for mankind. It gives people the peace of mind, hope and motivation.

The simplest definition of religion is to believe in supernatural and place it sacred or divine. Practice on certain values and rituals is also associated with this belief.

People have different religions or belief systems across the world which can be easily categorized into two categorizes: The divine religion and the non-divine (or worldly) religion. Non-divine religions are associated with great thinkers, philosophers and reformers. Out of many religions Hinduism and Budhism are the oldest. Rest of other non-divine religions are branches of these two. While divine religions are those which are revealed from God to different prophets. Three of them are still in practice: Judaism, Christianity and Islam.

These religions are being discussed below.

Hinduism

Hindus believe in thousands of gods and godesses, while there are two equally supreme gods: Shiva and Vishnu. At the same time they also believe that the entire universe is one divine entity and rest of other gods are attributes of that entity. It shows that they recognize a single deity. Hindus believe that based upon the activities and deeds of someone in his life he will transfer into another body and be reborn. Due to the bad deeds he may transform into an animal. Thus the life becomes a continuous cycle of birth, death and rebirth. Hindus believe in a caste system which is also associated with their religion.[1]

Budhism

Siddhartha Gautama later on called “Buddha” (the Enlightened One) was the founder of Budhism that is based on his personal and spiritual development. He explained that due to negative thinking, people suffer from worries, problems and sufferings while happiness, love,

[1] Manusmrity (Manav Dharma Shastra) Chapter:1

passion, peace of mind and good fortune is linked with the positive state of mind. As people think positively, they become clean and light, till the point when their souls attain enlightenment and gradually transform their present confused and self-centered state of mind into the blissful mind of a Buddha. Once this circle is completed then the soul reborn without its own choice.[2]

All other wordly religions are derived from these two religions and have an influence of them. Now have a look on monotheistic religions.

Judaism

Prophet Abraham (AS) preached the concept of One God among Hebrews 4000 years ago. He invited people towards the oneness of Allah (SWT) and the fear of the day of judgement. There was a chain of prophets in the siblings of Abraham (AS). Abraham's son, Prophet Isaac (AS) had a son, named Prophet Jacob (AS), also called Israel. The followers of these prophets are called Israelites. They were bound to obey the laws of Allah (SWT) which were given to Prophet Moses (AS) in written form on Mount Sinai. This book is called Torah or more commonly Old Testament.

Christianity

Christianity grew out of Judaism. It is also a monotheistic religion that is based on the life, teachings and miracles of Prophet Jesus also called “Christ”. His followers believe that he is son of God and the supreme power, along with God and Holy Spirit. The three of them are one while at the same time they are three.

The book revealed to Prophet Jesus is called Bible or New Testament. According to the believers, Prophet Jesus was crucified, killed, burried in a tomb and he rose three days later. Then he disappeared into the heaven. By his crucifixion, he paid off the sins of his followers. He also demonstrated his power over life and death and therefore has the power to give people an eternal life.They also believe that Christ will appear again and save the humanity, that is why he is also called Maseah. [3]

Islam

The arabic word “Islam” is derived from a word meaning “peace”, while “Islam” stands for willing submission to Allah (SWT). One can not achieve the peace of mind and soul until he does not surrender himself in front of Allah (SWT) and live his life according to His laws.

Islam is not a new religion. It is an extension of Judaism and Bible because submission to the will of God’ has always been the only acceptable religion in the sight of God. For this reason,

[2] Sitting Together, Sumi Loundon Kim, Wisdom Publications

[3] The Significance of the Death and Resurrection of Jesus for the Christians, Australian Catholic University National.

it is the same eternal message revealed through the ages to all of God's Prophets and Messengers. The prophethood started with Adam, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, David, Solomon, Jesus, and Ismail, peace be upon them, all conveyed this main message that there is only One True God and He alone is to be worshipped. God says in the Quran,

"We did not send before you (O Mohammad) any messenger but We revealed to him: 'none has the right to be worshipped except I, therefore worship Me.'" (Quran 21:25)

However, the true message of these prophets was either lost or got corrupted over time and hence lost its credibility to guide the people towards the right path. Therefore, 600 years after Jesus, God purified the lost message by sending the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) with His final revelation, the Holy Quran, towards all the mankind. It was the revival of humanity. Since the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) was the final prophet, God Himself has promised to preserve His last revealed words so that it would remain the source of guidance for all humanity till the Last Day. It is now imperative for everyone to believe and follow this final message from God. God Almighty says in the Quran,

"We have not sent you (O Mohammad) but to all mankind as a giver of good news and as a warner, but most people do not know." (Quran 34:28)

"Whoever seeks a religion other than Islam, it will never be accepted of him, and in the Hereafter, he will be one of the losers." (Quran 3:85)

The word "Muslim" means one who submits to the will of God, regardless of his/her race, nationality or ethnic background. Hence, any person who is ready to submit to the will of God is eligible to become a Muslim.

Existence of God and Oneness of Allah (SWT)

Before we start studying religion, the first question which comes to our mind is, ”Is there any God?” In this regard to prove the existence of Allah (SWT) there are many evidences for anybody who wants to weigh the matter. Some arguments are given for the existence of God.

1. Fitrah Arguments

Everybody feels deep inside that there is a Creator of him which he needs all the time. When he is in calamity, he turns towards his Supreme Lord. He seeks help, guidance and gets hope from his Lord.

Fitrah is the intrinsic nature in humans which guides them about wrong and right deeds. Everybody is conscious about the moral values, though they differ culturally but the basic values are same. Murder, theft, kidnapping, mischievious behavior etc are disliked by everybody, in every nation and in every religion.

Throughout the history every society placed some people or figures to a higher position to seek help and to sanctify their feelings.

Islam is the religion of fitrah as stated in the Quran,

Therefore, set right your face for the obedience of Allah being one devoted to Him only. The established pattern of Allah upon which He has created mankind. No change in the created things of Allah. This is the only right religion. But most of the people know not. (Ar Room 30:30)

The right religion is described as fitrah of Allah (SWT). Syyedena Abu Hurera (RA) mentioned that fitrah is associated with the deen of Islam. Since Allah (SWT)'s fitrah is engraved on the human soul, mankind is born with the concept of Tauheed (Oneness of Allah (SWT)). Since Tauheed is intrinsic to man’s fitrah, so the prophets, peace be upon them, came to remind mankind about the fundamental reality of the original nature.

Islam is deen-e-fitrah, the religion of human nature as its teachings and laws are integrated and in full harmony with human nature by which he submits himself to the Creator.

2. Design and Designer Argument

Every thing in the universe did not come into being by chance. The placement of the things reflects the designer and his design. Every object and all living things have specific designs which indicate its designer.

If there were two or more designers of the world then they should be independent in their domain and each of them wants to show and prove his existence. If they were different in their existence, their attributes would be different. In this case the harmony of the world could be disturbed. They may manipulate each others domain.

He for Whom is the kingdom of heavens and earth and He has not taken a son for Himself and He has no partner in His kingdom, and after creating everything, He has ordained it on a right estimate.
(Al-Furqan, 25/2)

Proof for Existence of God (A)

All divine religions believe in the supermacy of God. Except Islam, the other divine religions (Christianity & Judaism) made religious corruption, hence the main message of God was lost or made doubtful. As a monotheistic religion, the basic belief of Islam is to believe in Allah's existence and oneness. There are many proofs that demonstrate His existence and oneness all around.

Scientific Proof

Strictly speaking, an intelligent design cannot be developed by any un-intelligent sources. In all of the universe, order cannot come out of chaos. Several interesting phenomena in science discuss about the existence of God, particularly the notion of the Big Bang Theory of creation of our universe. In 1920s a scientist Edwin Hubble studied the movement of stars and galaxies and he observed that the stars and galaxies are drifting apart from each other. Moreover, he filled the dotted balloon with air and observed that those dots became distant from each other as more and more air was coming into the balloon. He applied this analogy to the expansion of the universe like a balloon and galaxies are like dots on it, which are going far away from each other at the rate of the expansion. If the process is reversed everything would get focused back to a single point where this has started. Hence the universe began from a single point in time equal to zero.

The law of conservation of mass states that mass can neither be created nor be destroyed. For example you cannot create a pen from nothing, nor can you destroy it completely. However, the primary questions regarding the mass which now have turned into an immeasurable and infinite universe "Where has it come from?" and "What had happened before the advent of the Big Bang?" are still unanswered. Though, this law also leads us to think of some authority which has created this mass and gave it all its attributes.

We logically have three options about the existence of the ball of mass: first it was created from nothingness, second, the ball was created by itself and finally, someone created it. Now, we know very well that something cannot be created from void. To nullify the second option, it's impossible for something to be in a state of existence and non-existence at the same time; that means how can something create another while it does not exists yet. So we are left with third choice, some being has created that mass ball which had the capacity to expand.

We have different strengths to do certain things in life but our strengths are limited. Hazrat Musa (AS) and Hazrat Khizar (AS) were on a journey as a trial of of patience of Musa (AS).

Khizar (AS) told him that our knowledge is as small as a water droplet in the beak of a bird and the remaining ocean is as the knowledge of God. Allah has raised these challenging arguments to mankind that “Do you think you created this world?”, “Do you think the universe created itself?” and “Do you think someone has created it?”.

The magnificient system of universe proves the existence of Allah (SWT). There is a delicately balanced system in the world. The great and complex rotation of the earth around itself and around the sun; the consecutive formation of the four seasons, and the days and nights, the wind, rain and snow, the watercycle and the growing and proliferation of living beings work in an entire order.

The universe and the things around consist of atoms. An atom is wonderfully designed and has a great energy. It is like a small solar system with its nucleus in the centre and the electrons rotating around it. This incredible system is squeezed into such a small space that it cannot be seen through a naked eye. The One who created an atom, is He who created the whole universe.

The complexed but perfect structure of the human body indicates the existence of Allah. All the cells and parts of our body operate in consistency. A cell is perfectly designed which is the building block of living beings. In every cell, there exists a very detailed instruction code, much like a miniature computer program. The DNA code in each of the cells is very similar to a computer program. It is made up of four chemicals that scientists abbreviate as A, T, G, and C. These are arranged in the human cell like this: CGTGTGACTCGCTCCTGAT and so on like a computer program code 101001101011100. There are three billion of these chemicals in every human cell. Thus the existence of a little cell is only possible through the power of Allah. The complicated structure of brain, eye, heart, muscles etc invites man to think about the Creator.

Undoubtedly, there are signs in the heavens and the earth
for the believers. (Surah Al-Jaathiya 45:3)

Proof for Existence of God (B)

The Religious Perspective

Islam is not a new religion but it is the extension and completion of previous divine religions. Existence of Allah is solid in terms of its rational foundations as well as the purpose, meaning, comfort, and guidance that it gives to our lives. There is an authentic, sound purpose and meaning of this universe. Hence, the early scholars of Islam defined knowledge of God not as a collection of facts and arguments, but rather as a light within the heart.

The "light" of the knowledge of God is found I n the guidance, spiritual direction and the sense of peace that one can attain by practicing Islam. The greatest proof for the existence and lordship of Allah is discovered in the innate experiences of the heart. These experiences help to find comfort, inner-peace, moral education and meaning in the life of believers which are the spiritual fruits of a true religion.

In Christianity, Judaism, Hinduism, Sikhism and Zoroastrians, the concept of oneness of God is prevailing with minute differences. They have many other gods but deep inside they believe in one single God. That is why they ask help from the Lord of lords, even the atheist seek help of God in time of crisis. Even in the ancient civilizations, the belief in One God existed. Later, they turned to polytheism (belief in more than one God). But the concept of monotheism (belief in one God) was there in one or another form. In Quran, the Oneness of God is declared in Surah Ikhlas.

Allah addressed to every nation in the Quran that we have sent a messenger to teach them to worship One and real God and leave the other and false deities. The concept of Oneness of God is primitive among the ancient tribes and societies even in America before Columbus. A famous Muslim historian and a scholar Abdullah Hakeem quickly and extensively studied the attributes of different tribes of the world and found that the concept of Oneness of God is a common belief among all societies which later has been corrupted into polytheism. This is one good evidence about the presence of the oneness of God among all the tribal inhabitants of the world in different times.

In perspectives of comparative analysis of the contemporary religions in the world, we can see that the concept of prophethood, miracles and acceptance of "dua" (prayers) are the common beliefs. These facts cannot be easily fabricated by any rank of human race. These luring facts also nullify the objections and fabricated stories about the refusal of the arrival of prophets and their teachings regarding the Oneness of God. On the contrary, it intensified the rightfulness and refuted the non-believers.

The stories and events of Prophet Adam and Eve, Prophet Moses, Prophet Ibrahim, Prophet Yaqoob, Prophet Yusuf and Prophet Essa (Jesus) (Peace Be Upon Them) are commonly

discussed in almost every religion. Although, there are differences in the revelations and sequence of events but the divine message is same. Muslims believe that all prophets are infallible, they are not the sin-doers whereas in the previous scripts like Bible they labeled them as the sinners.

Allah (SWT) has created His creatures to worship Him only. We, the humans and another creature known as Jinn are also mentioned in Quran with the purpose of their creation that is to worship Him alone.

The script of the Quran does not contain anything that is impossible according to rational thinking or that would be rejected by any reason. Also, there isn't any argument that contradicts the reason or any analogy based on rational thinking. Whereas the proponents of falsehood never presented any analogy to support their ideology but the Qur'an refuted it on the basis of truthful and clear argument.

All creations by Allah (SWT) are created only to worship Him. Animals and Jinn are also His creation. Iblees (Azazil) is a jinn but was so pious that he became the companion of angels, but his arrogance made him evil.

Mankind is different as they can speak. They have intellect and can think. The intellect is a gift from Allah.

He for Whom is the kingdom of heavens and earth and He has not taken a son for Himself and He has no Partner in His Kingdom, and after creating everything, He has ordained it on a right estimate. (Surah Al-Furqan: 25/2)

Purpose of Life

We have discussed that someone is the creator of this universe, the Quran is the holy manual to lead our lives. Messengers from God have been coming since the first day to guide mankind. We found in Quran, "For every nation we have sent the messenger, saying that, only worship one God and leave other false deities." Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is the last prophet and his message will remain till the day of judgement. As Prophet Mohmmad (PBUH) raised his two fingers and said, "My coming and hour are like this. After me, there is no messenger, no book but only the day of judgement".

Now the question is Why have we been created? What's the purpose of our lives?

1. Tests of Life

In search of our purpose of life, what we find in the Quran is:

"(Allah) Who has created death and life, that He may test you which of you is best in deed." [Al-Mulk 67:2]

Everything that we do is our test and we will be judged for our response to it. We have the freedom to choose our path but the consequence will depend on our actions. The test could be anything. Allah (SWT) can test us with good things and even with unpleasant things such as children, health, wealth or death of near one.

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) says, "How strange is the case of a believer that if good befalls him and he feels grateful to Allah then it is good for him if something bad happens for him and he does sabr (Patience) then even that is good for him." Because through sabr (Patience) Allah (SWT) can bestow him such ranks which he could never achieve otherwise. We just should choose the best option to succeed in those tests, as Allah (SWT) has bestowed us with the power of choosing the best option.

"We have certainly created man in the best of stature". (Surah At-Tin 95:4)

So, if we strive, we can raise our status higher than the angels and if we won't we can be worse than animals. Allah (SWT)'s judgement is fair to everyone. The punishment of our sins in this world may relieve some of our sins. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said that even if a thorn pricks you, some of your sins will be wiped off through that. Likewise, illness is a way of purification of sins. There are some sins for which we can be punished both in this world and the afterlife. Quran states the example of Pharaoh, we are making an example out of him and we will punish him in the mornings and afternoons (which means in his grave) and when the day of judgement will establish, his punishment will be doubled.

Leaving righteous offspring can be beneficial to raise our ranks in the afterlife. Besides, there are some deeds like Sadqa-e-Jaria whose rewards will be endlessly received to us even after our deaths. The deeds like planting a tree, beneficial knowledge that you may have passed to anyone, building a mosque, donating a wheelchair etc. We will be rewarded on such things.

Repentance is the key to free from the consequences of sins. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, “remorse is repentance”.

As far as Haqooq-ul-Allah is concerned, Allah (SWT) forgives after true repentance. For Haqooq-ul -Aibaad, one must seek forgiveness from the person whom he hurt.

At the Day of Judgment, sinners will have to give up their good deeds. For example, If we have committed the sin of backbiting of someone then our good deeds will be added to his/her account of good deeds. Our punishments in this world can reduce the effect of a sin or some could be saved for the afterlife unless we repent. It is best to recite Astaghfaar (forgiveness) abundantly. Prophet Mohmmad (PBUH) said that I make Astaghfaar 70 times in a day although he was not a sinner, as prophets of Allah (SWT) cannot sin.

Everyone will have to face tests of life according to his level. Allah (SWT) says,

“Allah does not charge a soul except (with that within) its capacity”. (Surah Al-Baqarah, 286)

Insane or mentally retarded people are not accountable for their sins as they do not have any control over themselves.

2. Worship of The One, Allah Almighty

Secondly, Allah (SWT) also said in the Quran:

“And I did not create the jinn and mankind except to worship Me”. (Surah Adh-Dhariyat, 56)

Worship doesn’t only mean offering prayers or fasting. All of our actions can be the acts of worship if we intend to please Allah (SWT) and keep ourselves away from disobeying Him.

In the modern world, the word “slavery” is considered very disgraced. While in the perspective of worship and relation of a man and god, slavery refers to our obedience to our Master. Prophet Mohmmad (PBUH) is the best of Mankind. He said, “No me as nothing more than Abduhu wa Rasuluho (No me means) slave and messenger”.

Allah (SWT) defines slaves as Ibaad-ur-Rehman.

“And the servants of the Most Merciful are those who walk upon the earth easily, and when the ignorant address them [harshly], they say [words of] peace.” (Surah Furqan, 63).

If we are successful in our materialistic ambitions but have not become the slave of Allah (SWT), then technically we have failed in our purpose of life.

Islam is the most practical religion. Quran has many miracles such as the laws stated by Allah (SWT) in Quran demonstrate the perfect distribution of rights for everyone. Or the punishments for certain sins have a certain sense. Like the punishment of cutting hands for theft demonstrate that no one should dare to commit such a crime in future. Similarly, the law of inheritance in Islam is flawless as women take the inheritance from their fathers, also what she receives from her husband belongs to her and she is not responsible for taking care of others. While the major part of inheritance goes to the man, who is responsible for taking care of his mother, sisters, daughters, sons, father and wife.

“O mankind! Fear your Lord the One Who created you from a soul single and created from it its mate and dispersed from both many men and women”. (Surah An-Nisa, 1)

Divine religions were all monotheistic, which afterwards were being changed by people. Allah (SWT) says in the Quran:

“Indeed, the religion in the sight of Allah is Islam.” (Surah Al-Imran,19)

Islam literally means two things: submission and peace. For us, it is important to live and die as a Muslim. Allah (SWT) says in the Quran:

O you who have believed, fear Allah as He should be feared and do not die except as Muslims [in submission to Him]. (Surah Al-Imran, 102)

Tauheed and Shirk

Tauheed

Tauheed means attributing Oneness to Allah (SWT) and describing Him as being One and Unique, with no partner or peer in His Essence and Attributes.

Tauheed is the primary and core subject of the Quran. There is a Hadith which mentions that Surah Ikhlas is one third of the Quran. It means that Surah Ikhlas contains only the topic of tauheed, oneness of Allah (SWT).

Importance of Tauheed

Allah (SWT) has mentioned tauheed in two different and separate ways and styles in Quran:

"And We did not send any Messenger before you, but We revealed to him (saying): **none has the right to be worshipped but I (Allah)**, so worship Me (Alone)." **[Al-Anbiya:25]**

And at another place in Quran Allah (SWT) mentioned,

And verily, We have sent among every Ummah (nation) a Messenger (proclaiming): "**Worship Allah (Alone)**, and avoid (or keep away from) Taghut." **[An-Nahl:36]**

Both statements are diverse ways of proclaiming His Oneness and complete one another. At another place, He mentioned the name of His Prophet Hazrat Noah (AS) and His proclamation of Tauheed as,

"Indeed, We sent Nuh (Noah) to his people and he said: "**O my people! Worship Allah (SWT)**! You have no other Ilah (God) but Him." **[Surah Al-Araaf:59]**

Repeatedly stating the subject of Tauheed in diverse ways and styles at different places in Quran indicates the emphasis and importance on the belief of Tauheed. Allah (SWT) used the exact statement for other Prophets in Quran regarding Tauheed.

"And to 'Ad (people, We sent) their brother Hud. He said: "**O my people! Worship Allah (SWT)**! You have no other Ilah (God) but Him." **[Al-Araaf:65]**

"And to Thamud (people, We sent) their brother Salih (Saleh). He said: "**O my people! Worship Allah (SWT)!!** You have no other Ilah (God) but Him." **[Al-Araaf:73]**

“And to (the people of) Madyan, (We sent) their brother Shu'aib. He said: “**O my people! Worship Allah (SWT)!!** You have no other Ilah (God) but Him.” **[Al-Araaf:85]**

So, Allah (SWT) continued to mention the Oneness of Him, as the kalima of tauheed begins with “La” which means negation. So, one negates every other false God before accepting the oneness of Allah (SWT).

“And (remember) Hazrat Ibrahim (AS) when he said to his people: “**Worship Allah** (Alone), and fear Him, that is better for you if you did but know.” **[Al-Ankaboot:16]**

“But the Hazrat Messiah Isa (AS) (Jesus) said: “O Children of Israel! **Worship Allah, my Lord and your Lord.**” Verily, whosoever sets up partners (in worship) with Allah (SWT), then Allah (SWT) has forbidden Paradise to him, and the Fire will be his abode.” **[Al-Maeda:72]**

“Say (O Mohammad): “But in truth **He (Allah) is the only one God**. And truly I am innocent of what you join in worship with Him.” **[Al-Anaam:19]**

So, till last messenger the message of Oneness of Allah (SWT) was sent to mankind which shows its high importance.

Shirk - The Unforgivable Sin

“And indeed, it has been revealed to you (O Mohammad), as it was to those before you: "If you join others in worship with Allah (SWT), (then) surely (all) **your deeds will be in vain**, and you will certainly be among the losers.” **[Az-Zumar:65]**

This was said to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), that even if you do shirk with Allah (SWT) then all of your good deeds will be wasted.

“Verily, Allah (SWT) **forgives not** that partners should be set up with Him, but He forgives what is less than that to whomever He wills...” **[An-Nisa:48]**

These references of ayahs from Quran shows that Shirk is an unforgivable sin. Hazrat Noah (AS) said to his people; Even if you seek repentance, not only Allah (SWT) forgives you but He will send rain from the sky, He will give you prosperity, He will increase your wealth and children and He will bestow upon you gardens and rivers.

This shows that if someone has committed the sin of shirk and then seek repentance on it from then Allah (SWT) forgives him but if someone dies on the belief of shirk then surely, he will meet the fire in Hell.

Now a question arises, why Shirk is so unforgivable sin?

Shirk is to associate someone other than Allah (SWT) in those aspects which are unique to Allah (SWT) and His exclusive right. Shirk is to worship created beings like Allah (SWT) is

worshipped, to venerate created beings like Allah (SWT) must be venerated, and to assign a portion of His divinity to someone else.
So, at the day of judgement Allah (SWT) will ask that person who did shirk that as you have done this deed for another person or god other than Me then ask the reward of it from that false God.

In the Bible, it is mentioned that at the day of judgement, people will come to Prophet Jesus and will ask him that O Lord, O Lord, we did charity in Thy name and they will mention their good deeds in Prophet Jesus's name. While Prophet Jesus will say that get away you evil doers, I even don't know you?

And in Quran, Allah (SWT) has mentioned that on day of Judgement when people will come to Prophet Jesus, Allah (SWT) will ask Prophet Jesus, "O Eesa, did you tell them to worship you besides Me? Or your mother besides Me?" and Prophet Jesus will say, Ya Allah (SWT) you know what is in my heart, I have never told them to worship me".

Our intrinsic nature, Fitrah is inclined towards the Oneness of God and all the design of the nature shows the glory and Oneness of a single Designer, hence that made the shirk an unforgivable sin as all the proves of oneness of God are present in ourselves. So, one has to go against their own nature to do shirk.

Repentance Before Death

There is a Sahih Hadith, an old man came to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) with a stick in his hand as a support for walking, He said to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) what do you say about a person who has committed every sin, big or small, he has not left any of it? Ya RasullAllah (SAW)! I am an old man I have done that all. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said Have you said Shahdah? He said yes.

Then Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, from this moment, you do righteous deeds and don't go back to those sins, Allah (SWT) will forgive you and will turn your bad deeds in to good deeds.

That person was shocked and said that even my treachery and the way I hurt other people will be forgiven? Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, yes even those, and then he lifted his stick and went back with slogans of Allahu Akbar Allahu Akbar.

Real repentance changes us and our ways of life.

Types of Tauheed

1. Rububiyah (Lordship)

2. Uluhiyyah (Worship)

3. Asmaa Was-Sifaat (Names and Attributes)

1. Rububiyah (Lordship)

- This category is based on the fundamental concept that Allah (SWT) alone caused all things to exist when there was nothing.
- He sustains and maintains creation without any need from it or for it and He is the sole Lord of the universe and its inhabitants without any real challenge to His sovereignty.
- In Arabic, the word used to describe this creator sustainer quality is Rububiyah which is derived from the root "Rabb" (Lord). This is proved by Allah's (SWT) statement in Surah Al-Fatihah, verse one where He says, "[All] praise is [due] to Allah, Lord of the worlds [mankind, jinn and all that exists]".
- According to this category, since God is the only real power in existence, it is He who gave all things the power to move and to change.
- Most of mankind except atheist believes in Rububiyah.

2. Uluhiyyah (Worship)

It is also called Ubudiyah. This means having a firm conviction that only Allah is the true God worthy of worship. In Arabic, the term 'ibadah' (worship) is associated with obedience, subservience and submission. It has been defined by some scholars as "complete love accompanied by complete submission". Thus, worship in all its forms cannot be dedicated to anyone else besides Allah (SWT). It is important to point out that the concept of worship is all-embracing. Worship transcends the five pillars of Islam and covers all the good things and deeds which please Allah (SWT). Therefore, things like supplication, reliance, obedience, subservience and submission would be covered by this definition. All these things should be done solely for the sake of Allah (SWT).

Evidence of this type of Tauheed is in Allah's (SWT) statement "And I Allah did not create the jinn and men except that they should worship Me (alone)". **[Surah An-Nahl: 36]**

- **'Kalima' as an example of Uluhiyyah**

- ilah- one who is worshipped, on account of greatness and power is considered worthy to be worshipped.
- **La ilaha illallah** –There is no ilah other the one great being known by the name Allah (SWT).
- It means that in whole of the universe, there is absolutely no being worthy to be worshipped other than Allah (SWT).
- That is only to Him our heads should bow in submission and adoration.

Our Prayers, charity, dua, tawaf, sajda etc are the acts of worship. If we perform them for anyone else other than Allah (SWT) then it is Shirk.

3. Asmaa Was-Sifaat (Names and Attributes)

This category of Tauheed has five main aspects:

- Unity of Allah's (SWT) names and attributes to be maintained in the first aspect.
- Allah (SWT) must be referred to according to how He and His Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) have described Him instead explaining His names and attributes by giving them meanings other than their obvious meanings.
- The second aspect of Tauheed al-Asmaa wasSifaat involves referring to Allah (SWT) as He has referred to Himself without giving Him any new names or attributes.
- In the third aspect of Tauheed al-Asmaa wasSifaat, Allah (SWT) is referred to without giving Him the attributes of His creation. For example, it is claimed in the Bible and Torah that Allah (SWT) spent the first six days creating the universe then slept on the seventh. For this reason, Jews and Christians take either Saturday or Sunday as a day of rest in which work is looked at as a sin.
- The fourth aspect of Tauheed al-Asmaa wasSifaat requires that man not be given the attributes of Allah (SWT) to His Almighty level. E.g a man can be Raheem but not to the level of Allah (SWT).
- Maintaining the unity of Allah's (SWT) names also means that Allah's (SWT) names in the definite form cannot be given to His creation unless preceded by the prefix 'Abd meaning "slave of" or "servant of'.

Shirk of Followers of Hazrat Noah (AS)

People of Hazrat Noah (AS) are the first one to commit the crime of shirk.

In a hadith narrated by Hazrat Ibn ‘Abbaas (R.A), the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: “There were ten generations between Adam and Noah, all living according to Islam. The descendants of Adam started to slowly lose their religion and began committing sins, but they still believed in Tauheed – the unity of Allah (SWT). Ignorance was spreading amongst them. And the righteous amongst them were few.

Shaytaan came to them and said, “When these righteous men pass away, you will have no one to remind you of Allah (SWT) and about ‘ibaadah. You will have no one to give you naseehah and advice. So how about, when they pass away, you erect some statues in their memorial to remind you about ‘ibaadah?” Because these righteous men used to give them naseehah and advice. They followed the advice of shaytaan, thinking that it was a good advice. They erected these idols and hung them in market places and houses.

Then, shaytaan left them alone. Look at how patient he is with his plan. He left them until they forgot why these statues were built. After this generation passed away and new generation came and the people forgot why these were erected. Shaytaan came to them and told them, “Why don’t you put those statues in the mosques, I am not saying to put them in front but at least put them at the back of mosque, so they would remind you about righteous

people and you would never forget to follow your role models?" They followed the advice of shaytaan and put the statues at the back of the mosque.

After this generation passed away and new generation came and the people forgot why these were erected in mosque. Then shaytaan came for third time and said to them, "these are your pious people and you show back to them, please put them in front. In this way, you can offer your Salah attentively with the pious and righteous people in front of you as a reminder of piety for you. They followed the advice of shaytaan and put the statues at the front of the mosque.

When that whole generation passed away and there was a new generation who didn't knew why those idols were put there in front of mosque. Then Iblees came for the fourth time and said, "You are not supposed to talk to Allah (SWT) directly, you are nothing, you have to talk to those idols who can talk to Allah (SWT) on your part." And this is how shirk started.

Allah mentioned these 5 idols in the Qur'an: *wadd, suwa', yaghuth, ya'ooq* and *nasr*. (see 71:23) Hazrat Ibn 'Abbaas (RA) says that these were righteous men, whom the people of Nuh started to worship as their idols.

Types of Shirk

The texts of the Quran and Sunnah indicate that shirk and the ascribing of rivals to Allah (SWT) sometimes puts a person beyond the pale of Islam and sometimes does not. Hence the scholars divided shirk into two types which they call shirk akbar (major shirk) and shirk asghar (minor shirk)**.**

I. Major Shirk

This means ascribing to someone other than Allah (SWT) something that belongs only to Allah (SWT), such as Lordship (ruboobiyyah), divinity (uloohiyyah) and the divine names and attributes (al-asma' wa'l-sifaat).

Major Shirk may sometimes take the form of beliefs:

- Such as the belief that there is someone else who creates, gives life and death, reigns or controls the affairs of the universe along with Allah (SWT).
- Or the belief that there is someone else who must be obeyed absolutely besides Allah (SWT), so they follow him in regarding as permissible or forbidden whatever he wants, even if that goes against the religion of the Messengers.
- Or they may associate others with Allah (SWT) in love and veneration, by loving a created being as they love Allah (SWT). This is the kind of shirk that Allah (SWT) does not forgive.
- Or the belief that there are those who know the Unseen as well as Allah (SWT). It is also shirk to believe that there is someone who bestows mercy in a manner that is befitting only for Allah (SWT), so he shows mercy as Allah (SWT) does and forgives sins and overlooks the bad deeds of his worshippers.

II. Minor Shirk

This includes everything that may lead to major shirk, or which is described in the scripts as being shirk, but does not reach the extent of being major shirk.

This is usually of two types:

1- Being emotionally attached to some means which have no basis and for which Allah (SWT) has not given permission, such as hanging up “hands”, turquoise beads, amulets, etc on the grounds that they offer protection or that they ward off the evil eye. But Allah (SWT) has not made them the means of such protection, either according to shareeah or according to the laws of the universe.

2- Venerating some people or things in a way that does not go so far as ascribing lordship to them, such as swearing by something other than Allah (SWT), or saying, “Were it not for Allah and So and so,” etc.

Quran and Its Proofs

As Allah (SWT) is the creator of this universe then assuredly, He must have developed the user manual of this complicated universe. In our world, there are many manuals out there who claimed to be comprehensive e.g. Quran, Bible, Geeta, Torah, Buddhist scripture etc. The Question is which manual we should follow? Also, we must search that, is Quran the word of God? If it is the word of God then it means we must follow it.
There are 5 ways to testify that Quran is the word of God.

Proof for Quran

1. Falsification Test
2. Scientific Phenomenon
3. Non-Muslim Sources
4. Preservation of the Texts
5. Linguistic Miracle

1. Falsification Test

To verify the theory, we must give a test that whether our proposed theory is correct or not. So, the question is that does Quran give the falsification test? If it's a truthful book, we will find/verify by this test.

Quran itself proves, as Allah (SWT) said:

- Do they not then consider the Qur'an carefully? Had it been from other than Allah (SWT), they would surely have found therein many contradictions." [Surah an-Nisa 4:82]

There is no clash in statements of Quran.

- At another place, Allah (SWT) says "If you think that it is from other than Allah (SWT) then produce a Book like it". Allah (SWT) then made this challenge easy to come up with only 10 Surahs like Quran and then this challenge was even made easier to make a single surah like Quran and then Allah (SWT) said, they can never do this.

Another ayah says, even if all mankind and Jinn work together, they cannot produce a single ayah like Quran. By this it is also proved that Quran is a Holy Book and word of God.

2. Scientific Phenomenon

As discussed earlier that oneness & existence of Allah (SWT) can be observed / recognized by His signs all around. He also stated those signs for mankind in his Holy Book.

- Allah (SWT) mentioned scientific phenomena in Quran like stages of human life-embryology, creation of mountains, plants, water cycle etc. Quran is very clear about these facts.
- Over 1000 of ayahs in Quran deal with science like Big bang theory, expansion of universe, creation from water etc.
- Many inventions have been done by Muslim scholars like Arabic numerals, discovery of 0, coffee, soaps etc. Islam and science are not two different poles.

3. Non-Muslim Sources

- What non-Muslims say about the Quran?
- There is a multi-volume encyclopedia, called the new catholic encyclopedia which looked at every detail but with the perspective of Christianity. They highlighted the work of Christians. In this encyclopedia, under the section of Quran, they mentioned that Quran is a revelation from God. So, a question has raised that if you have stated Quran as a revelation then we might have to believe in it which could question the truthfulness of Bible. So, Scholars of encyclopedia replied that we are academics and according to the facts, we have no choice but to state Quran as a revelation.

- In an article under the subject of the Qur'an, the New Catholic Church states:

"Over the centuries, many theories have been offered as to the origin of the Qur'an. Today no sensible man accepts any of these theories!"

4. Preservation of the Texts

- If all the religious books of all religions in this universe were thrown in a sea, which Book will come back? The answer is Quran. As its preservation, has been promised by the Allah (SWT) till the day of judgement.
- Besides it is preserved in the hearts of Muslims by memorizing it.

As now Quran has been proved as a holy book and preserved for 1400 years. It is a proved miracle of Allah (SWT) as nobody can change a single word in it. This holy manual has covered all the subjects of life. So, no one can negate that holy preaching were unapproachable to us.

5. Linguistic Miracle

The Quran is widely recognized as a miraculous book, for the unique style and presentation of the Arabic language. As Muslims worldwide know, the words and surahs contained in the Quran can only have come from Allah. Unlike other religious texts, the Quran famously issues

a challenge to all mankind to try and produce even one Surah just like it. To date, nobody has been able to meet the challenge, even though many have tried.

To a native English speaker, this challenge sounds like it can easily be met, especially if they have read an English translation of the Quran. But the Arabic language is so unique and powerful, that after studying it, one can realize the great difficulty (and impossibility) of ever producing a surah which can rival or stand against the surahs contained in the Quran.

There is abundant material available regarding the proof of Quran as a linguistic miracle. One detailed document on this topic is available on the following link. It is shared for reference.

Reference:

https://d1.islamhouse.com/data/en/ih_books/single2/en_quran_the_linguistic_miracle_linguisticmiracle.pdf

Surah Fatihah

The Quran is the word of Allah (SWT). Its literal meaning is "that which is often recited". Apart from other recitations, Muslims recite it five times a day in their prayers.

Besides its proper name, the Quran is also known as Mushaf (collection of sheet), Al-Kitab (The Book), Al-Furqan (The Discrimination), Al-Dhikr (The Exposition), Al-Bayan (The Explanation), Al-Burhan (The Argument), Al-Haqq (The Truth), Al-Tanzil (The Revelation), Al-Hikmat (The Wisdom), Al-Huda (The Guide).

The text of the Holy Quran has remained unchanged over the past 1400 years. The millions of copies of the Quran circulating in the world today are all identical down to a single letter. And this is not strange since God says in the Holy Quran that He Himself will guard this book.

Division of Quran in Surah's and Verses

The Holy Quran is divided into 30 parts, each one is called "Siparah.". It has 114 sections or chapters which are called "Surahs". Each Chapter of unequal length consists of individual "Ayat" or verses. These verses are not decided by human beings, but dictated by God. It is commonly believed that the number of verses in the Quran is 6,666. In fact, the total number of verses[1] in all chapters is 6,236, although this varies depending on how (or if) the Bismillah appearing at the start of each chapter is counted, Rakus are 558 and 14 Sajda[3] (prostrations) in the Holy Quran. Surah Al-Baqarah (Ch.2) is the longest Chapter, comprising 287 verses while Surah Al-Kauthar (Ch. 108) is the shortest with only four verses, including the tasmia.

Compilation of Quran

The compilation of Quran was done under the rightly guided Caliphs Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA) and Hazrat Usman (RA).

- **During Life of Holy Prophet Mohammad (PUBH)**

As the Quran was being revealed, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) made special arrangements to ensure that it was written down. Although the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH) himself could neither read nor write, he dictated the verses orally and instructed scribes to mark down the revelation on whatever materials were available: tree branches, stones, leather, and bones. The scribes would then read their writing back to the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH), who would check it for mistakes. With each new verse that was revealed, the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH) also dictated its placement within the growing body of text.

When the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH) passed away, the Quran has been fully written down. It was not in book form, however. It was recorded on different parchments and materials, held in the possession of the Companions of the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH).

- **During Life of Caliph Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA)**

After the death of the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH), the entire Quran continued to be remembered in the hearts of the early Muslims. Hundreds of the early Companions of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) had memorized the entire revelation, and Muslims daily recited large portions of the text from memory. Many of the early Muslims also had personal written copies of the Quran recorded on various materials.

Ten years after the Hijrah (632 C.E.), many of these scribes and early Muslim devotees were killed in the Battle of Yamama. While the community mourned the loss of their comrades, they also began to worry about the long-term preservation of the Holy Quran. Recognizing that the words of Allah (SWT) needed to be collected in one place and preserved, the Caliph Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA) ordered all people who had written pages of the Quran to compile them in one place. The project was organized and supervised by one of the Prophet Mohammad's (PBUH) key scribes, Hazrat Zayd bin Thabit (RA).

The process of compiling the Quran from these various written pages was done in four steps:

- Hazrat Zayd bin Thabit (RA) verified each verse with his own memory.
- Hazrat Umar ibn Al-Khattab (RA) verified each verse. Both men had memorized the entire Quran.
- Two reliable witnesses had to testify that the verses were written in the presence of the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH).
- The verified written verses were collated with those from the collections of other Companions.

This method of cross-checking and verifying from more than one source was undertaken with the utmost care. The purpose was to prepare an organized document which the entire community could verify, endorse, and use as a resource when needed.
This complete text of the Quran was kept in the possession of Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA), and then passed on to the next Caliph, Hazrat Umar ibn Al-Khattab (RA). After his death, they were given to his daughter Hazrat Hafsah (RA) (who was also a widow of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

- **During Life of Caliph Hazrat Usman (RA)**

During the third caliphate of Hazrat Usman (RA). The Muslim empire expanded greatly. Hazrat Usman (RA) learnt that some people were reading the Quran in a different way. Hazrat Usman (RA) thought that the original meaning of the true Quran might change as it has happened to other books of Allah (SWT). He ordered Hazrat Zaid Bin Thabit (RA) to make a true collection.

Hazrat Zaid Bin Thabit (RA) did this work with the help of other senior Muslims. They collected all the true copies of Quran and they ensured these contain only the words of the Prophet Mohammad (PUBH). They checked that they were written in the dialect of Quraish, because it was the Holy Prophets Mohammad (PUBH) speech. After much hard work, the collection was made.

Hazrat Usman (RA) ordered a number of copies of this authoritative collection to be made and had them sent to the major cities of the empire. He also ordered that all other versions of Quran should be destroyed to prevent this problem to arise again in the future.

All Qurans available in the world today are exactly identical to the Usmani version, which was completed less than twenty years after the death of Prophet Mohammad (PUBH).
Later, some minor improvements were made in the Arabic script (adding dots and diacritical marks), to make it easier for non-Arabs to read. However, the text of the Quran has remained the same.

Makki and Madani Surah

Out of the 114 Surahs, 86 Surahs were revealed in Makkah while 28 Surahs were revealed in Madinah. Most of the Makki Surahs' are shorter in length and deal with concepts regarding Tauheed, the oneness of Allah (SWT); good morals and conduct and life in the Hereafter – heaven and hell. The Makki Surahs' also contain passages regarding the Prophets sent by Allah (SWT) in the past. Usually, the Makki Surahs' contain the phrase (ya ayyuhannasu).

Madani Surahs are often longer than Makki Surahs. They deal with the practical aspects of life. Most of the laws of Shariah were revealed in Madinah, including laws relating to marriage, divorce, money matters and criminal sanctions. Usually, the Madani Surahs contain the phrase (ya ayyo hal lazeena aamanoo").

It is very useful to know about Makki-Madani chapters. It helps those who want to understand the occasions and circumstances of revelation. It also helps to know the "nasikh" (abrogating) and "mansukh" (abrogated) verses in the Quran. Naturally, the abrogated passage is the one called 'mansukh' while the abrogating one is called 'nasikh'.

Distribution of Quran in perspective of its contents

The contents of the Quran can be categorized into the following categories.

- The Creator
- Day of judgement
- History of Mankind
- Guidance
- Dawah

Surah Al-Fatihah (The Opening)

It is named Al-Fatihah, the Opening - because it opens the Book and with it, the recitation in prayer commences. It is also named Umm al-Quran- the Mother of the Quran, and Umm al-Kitab, the Mother of the Book because the meaning of the entire Quran is summarized therein. It is also named Sab'ul-Mathani, (the Seven Often Repeated Verses), Al-Hamd, (the Praise), Al-Shifa (The Cure) and Ar-Ruqya, the Spiritual Cure. Its recitation is a condition for the effectiveness of the prayer.

It is the Makkah Surah of the Holy Quran, which means that it was discovered on the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) while He (PBUH) was in Makkah, i.e. before migration to Madinah. It was initially the 5th chapter to be disclosed, but after Furqan-e-Hameed was assembled together, it was put at the beginning. Al-Fatihah itself means “The Opening” as this chapter comes right at the start of the Holy Book and serves as a Gateway to read the Quran-e- Majeed further. Moreover, it also serves as the starting of Salah.

It also has the honor of being the very first Surah that is made known completely. Although it consists of 7 Ayats only, it still explains the Veneration of the Almighty in a very comprehensive fashion and is a great mean of the supplication of asking Allah (SWT) for keeping one on the right path.

Virtues of Surah Al-Fatihah

There are many virtues associated with this Surah. Hazrat Abu Saeed al-Khudri (RA) narrates:

“While on a journey we halted at a place. A girl came to us and said: “The chief of this tribe has been stung by a scorpion and our men are not present, is there anybody amongst you who can recite something upon him to treat him?” Then, one of our men went along with her, although we did not think that he knew any such treatment. However, our friend went to the chief and recited something upon him and the chief was cured. Thereupon, the chief gave him thirty sheep and gave us all milk to drink. When he returned, we asked our friend: “Did you know anything to recite upon him to cure him?” He said: “No, I only recited Umm al-Kitab (i.e. Surah Al-Fatihah) upon him.” We said that do not do anything until we reach Madinah and ask the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) regarding this (practice and reward-whether the sheep were lawful or not for us).

Theme of Surah Al-Fatihah

Allah (SWT) has taught in this Surah to mankind to offer prayer to Him, who is the Lord of this universe before seeking guidance and Who alone can grant it. The reader should have a firm belief that the Creator of the universe is the source of all knowledge and the study of Quran can provide him guidance.

Islam requires a man to commence everything with the name of Allah (SWT). By doing this he will keep himself away from evil and wrong deeds. Then, there is the prayer of Allah (SWT)

Who is the Master, Owner, Sustainer, Provider, Guardian, Sovereign, Ruler, Administrator, and Organizer. Then it is added that He is the Master of the Day of Judgment, thus, everyone is accountable for his deeds. Mankind is the only worshiper of the Lord and for this reason, mankind is requesting for guidance in every walk of life. The guidance which makes mankind favorable is required. The one who will be astray will suffer the wrath of Allah (SWT).

Brief Tafseer of Surah Al-Fatihah

- **In the Name of Allah (SWT)**

  The first ayah of the Surah Al-Fatihah is:

  In the name of Allah, the Beneficent, the Most Merciful. [Surah Al-Fatihah 1:1]
  This phrase is known as the Bismillah. It is recommended to recite it before doing any action.

- **The Meaning of the letter Baa**

  The Baa in the Arabic language can have three different meanings:
  1) With - With / In the name of Allah (SWT)
  2) Seeking help - Seeking help from the name of Allah (SWT)
  3) Seeking blessing - Seeking blessing in the name of Allah (SWT)

- **The Meaning of al-Rahman and al-Raheem**

  Both these names are derived from the same root letters: raa, haa, meem; which means to have mercy. They are thus similar in meaning and both are connected to Allah's (SWT) Mercy. The fact that Allah (SWT) mentions two of His Names which have to do with Mercy, rather than Might and Power or so on, shows just how important this Attribute is.

  The difference between al-Rahman and al-Raheem is that al-Rahman refers to Allah's (SWT) Mercy to all of creation. It is His Mercy, which is extended to both believers and disbelievers; animals, and everything that exists. He says in the Qur'an:

  My Mercy encompasses all things. [Surah Al-A'raf:156]

  Al-Rahman, therefore, indicates the extreme vastness of Allah's (SWT) Mercy. It is mentioned in a hadith that Allah (SWT) divided Mercy into 100 parts and sent down only one part to this Dunya. It is from this one part of His Mercy that animals show mercy to their offspring [Sahih Muslim]. Al-Raheem refers to Allah's (SWT) Mercy, which is specific for the believers. He says in the Qur'an:

  And He is Full of Mercy to the Believers. [Surah Al-Ahzab:43]
  Al-Raheem, therefore, indicates the doing of an action.

- **All Praise is due to Allah (SWT)**

  The Second ayah is:

  All praise be to Allah (SWT), the Lord of all the worlds. [Surah Al-Fatihah 1:2]

  - **The Meaning of Hamd and the Difference between Hamd and Shukr**

  Hamd means praise and thankfulness. The scholars differed as to the relation between the words hamd and shukr. Some said that they both have the same meaning. So, the meaning of hamd, in their view, is the same as shukr (thankfulness, gratitude). Others said that shukr is more general than hamd. In that shukr is done with the tongue, the limbs, and the heart; whereas hamd is done with the tongue only.
  It is also said that hamd is more general than shukr. In hamd, it contains the meaning of shukr (thankfulness) as well as made (praise). Therefore, it is more general because hamd can take the place of shukr but shukr cannot take the place of hamd. Hamd is something which must be done with love and reverence, but shukr does not need this. Shukr is done in response to a favor which is done to a person but hamd is done simply because the one being praised and thanked is worthy of that.

  - **The Meaning of Rabb**

  Rabb is usually translated as Lord, but it is much more encompassing than that. It also includes the meaning of Nurturer, Sustainer, Cherisher and so on. The Rabb is the creator, king, master and the one who controls everything. It comes from the root letters raa, baa, baa: which means to have mastery and control over something. Some scholars said that this is the Greatest Name of Allah (SWT) [Ism Allah al-A'zam], because of its abundant usage by those who make Dua.

  - **The Meaning of 'Aalameen**

  Some of the differing views about it are that it refers to:
  - Everything which exists other than Allah (SWT)
  - Mankind and the jinn
  - Those things which have an intellect, and they are four: mankind, jinn, angels, and devils
  - Those species which have souls

  The best view is the first one, the proof being ayah 23 and 24 of Surah Shu'ara.

  [Surah Shu'ara:23] Said Pharaoh, "And what is the Lord of the worlds?"
  [Surah Shu'ara:24] [Moses] said, "The Lord of the heavens and earth and that between them, if you should be convinced."

- **The Beneficent, The Most Merciful** [Surah Al-Fatihah 1:3]
  The third ayah is:

  Both these names are derived from the same root letters: raa, haa, meem; which means to have mercy. They are thus similar in meaning and both are connected to Allah's (SWT) Mercy. The fact that Allah (SWT) mentions two of His Names which have to do with Mercy, rather than Might and Power or so on, shows just how important this Attribute is.

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  And He is Full of Mercy to the Believers. [Surah Al-Ahzab:43]
  Al-Raheem, therefore, indicates the doing of an action.

- **The Only Owner of the Day of Recompense.** [Surah Al-Fatihah 1:4]
  The Fourth ayah is:

  - **The Meaning of Maalik**

  The first word of this ayah can be recited in two ways: either as "Maalik" (with a madd after the meem) or as "Malik" (without the madd). Maalik means master, and it refers to "milk" - the ownership of something. Malik means king, and it refers to "mulk" - the dominion of a person.

  God is the Lord of the Day when all generations of mankind gathered together to render an account of their conduct, and when each person will be finally rewarded or punished for his deeds. The description of God as Lord of the Day of Judgement following the mention of his benevolence and compassion indicates that we ought to remember another aspect of God as well-namely, that He will judge us all, that He is so powerful, that on the Day of Judgement no one will have the power either to resist the enforcement of punishments to which He (SWT) decrees or to prevent anyone from receiving the rewards that He (SWT) decides to confer. Hence, we ought not only to love Him for nourishing and sustaining us and for His compassion and mercy

towards us, but should also hold Him in awe because of His justice, and should not forget that our ultimate happiness or misery rests completely with Him.

- **You (Alone) We Worship**

  The fifth ayah is:

  You (alone) we worship and You (alone) we ask for help. [Surah Al-Fatihah 1:5]

  At this point, there is a shift in the Surah from informing us about Allah (SWT) and praising Him, to addressing Him. "We worship" means we obey. Worship is obedience and self-abasement. It means to humble yourself before Allah (SWT) and to submit to His Will. Outwardly it is self-abasement, but in reality, it is glory and beauty. This ayah affirms the Lordship of Allah (SWT) and affirms that worship is due to Him.

  "Iyyaaka nasta'een" means we seek help, support, and success.
  Usually, in most sentences the verb comes first and then the object; but in this ayah, the object of the verb is mentioned first and then the verb. So why is this? It is to attach importance to it, to Allah (SWT). It is also so that the mention of the slave and of worship would not come before the mention of Allah (SWT).

- **Guide us on the Straight Path**

  The sixth ayah is:

  Guide us on the Straight Path. [Surah Al-Fatihah 6:1]

  This ayah is a dua which we make to Allah (SWT). We ask Him to show us the Straight Path and to guide us on it so that we will get His Guidance which draws us closer and nearer to Him. It could also mean that we ask Him to guide us to do all the Sunnah acts when doing our duty. And another possible meaning of it is, “Make our hearts lean towards the truth.”
  What is a path? It is a road, it's something which is traveled on, to take you from one point to another. So, it's not enough just to be on the path and then be stationary, we need to travel this path. We need to travel to Allah (SWT) by doing those good deeds which will draw us closer to Him, and by staying away from all evil deeds which will distance us from Him.

    - **The Meaning of Sirat**

  Sirat is a road or a path. But there are certain conditions which it has to fulfill in order to be a sirat otherwise it would be called something else, such as tareeq or Sabeel which also mean a road. The conditions are that it must be straight. It must reach the goal and it must be the shortest route to get there. It must also be wide and spacious enough for everyone who wants to travel it.

- **The Meaning of Mustaqeem**

Mustaqeem is derived from **istaqaama,** which means to be straight, upright, correct. We already said that for a road to be a sirat, it must be straight, so this adjective of mustaqeem again emphasize the straightness of this Path. Another meaning of mustaqeem is to remain firm or to stand firm without tilting. For example, a tree that is firmly grounded when the wind blows it is not affected by it. So, the Straight Path is a path on which people are firmly grounded.

- **The Path of Those…**

The seventh and final ayah is:

The path of those you have blessed, not of those with anger on them, nor of those who are astray. [Al-Fatihah 7:1]

Who are the people who have been blessed by Allah (SWT) and whose Path we ask to guide to? This is explained by Allah (SWT) in another ayah where He says: "Whosoever obeys Allah (SWT), and the Messenger, they are with those whom Allah (SWT) has favored, the Prophets (AS), the sincere, the martyrs and the righteous, and these are the best company". [Surah Al-Nisa:69]
So, the favored and blessed people are the Prophets, the righteous, the martyrs and the pious. And who are the people with anger on them and those who are astray? This is explained by the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). 'Hazrat Adi Ibn Hatim (RA) asked him about those with anger on them and the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) replied that it refers to the Jews. He then asked him about those who are astray and Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) replied that it refers to the Christians. This is reported by al-Tirmidhi and it is authentic.

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Surah Al-Baqarah

Introduction

Al-Baqarah (The Cow) has been named from the story of the Cow occurring in this Surah (verses 67-73) though this is not the only event discussed in this Surah.

This is a Madani Surah. Though the major part of this Surah was revealed during the first two years of the Holy Prophet Mohammad's (PBUH) life at Al-Madinah, it follows a Makki Surah Al- Fatihah, which ended with the prayer: "Show us the straight way." It begins with the answer to that prayer, "This is the Book (that)...is guidance..."

There are some Haroof-e-Muqatte'at in Qur'an. Allah (SWT) knows their literal and real meaning better alone. But in many commentaries of the Qur'an, it has been considered an established fact that these words were also the open challenge to the Polytheists, who considered themselves the most eloquent people of the world, they were challenged to create even a single surah of the same rank as were present in the Qur'an.

In this Surah, Allah (SWT) says that this is the Book of Allah (SWT) which has no doubts about it. It is the source of guidance for those who are piety and pious (muttaqis). The Qur'an is the only Book in this world which starts with the declarative statement that it is free of errors as well as the only Book that can guide us towards Allah (SWT) since guidance is the most precious blessings of Allah (SWT). Worldly things cannot match to it. Since, it is forbearance (Taqwa), an innate feeling of fear of Allah, which will lead to guidance. Therefore, the Qur'an is the source of guidance for the pious (muttaqis).

The Characteristics of Success

Allah (SWT) has mentioned five characteristics of successful people in the first five verses (ayats) of this Surah. They are discussed here in details.

1. **Believe in the Ghaib (Unseen)**

The first teaching of this verse (ayat) is the Believe in the unseen (Ghaib). We have to believe in Allah, Angels, the Books, the Messengers, the day of judgement and the divine decree. Allah (SWT) has created everything in a systematic way. Angels perform different duties assigned to them. More than 100,000 prophets had emerged to guide the humanity. There are five divine scriptures mentioned in the Qur'an, but there are even more Holy scribes revealed on different messengers of Allah (SWT) for the guidance of His people. The firm belief in Allah will never let you be disappointed in hard times of life. We can see how the prophets of Allah (SWT) have believed strongly in Allah (SWT) and they have come out of hardships with success due to their strong belief in Allah (SWT). Prophet Ibraheem (AS), Prophet Ayub (AS), Prophet

Yousaf (A.S), and many more. Even the last Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and his companions (R.A) were tested and successfully fulfilled the requirements of a pious Muslim and so, Allah (SWT) never disappointed them. One can see the last words of Hazrat Ali (RA), while He was stabbed in the state of prostration, said: 'By Lord of the Ka'aba (Allah), Hazrat Ali (RA) found the success.' What level of belief would Hazrat Ali (RA) had in Allah (SWT) while the spear is stabbed in from His back and it came out of His chest and He swore on an oath by the Lord of the Ka'aba.

2. The Establishment of Salat (Namaz)

The second important characteristic is Prayer/Salat (Namaz) if a person does good deeds, but ignores his Prayers, all his good deeds will not get the proper weight age. If one deliberately misses a single prayer, he will be considered out of the fold of Islam. Prayer differentiates a Muslim from a non-Muslim. This fact enforces the importance of Salat/Namaz. Prayers to save us from evil wicked deeds. Moreover, people have respect for the person who prays regularly. Prayer is set obligation upon us all.

3. The Charity

The third important aspect is the charity. We must help poor, needy and deserving people financially for the sake of Allah (SWT). Although the charity is not specifically related to money, it may be your time, strengths, abilities, knowledge, energy and everything that you can utilize to benefit the humanity for the sake of Allah (SWT). Every person must figure out about his strengths and to employ them in the path of Allah (SWT). The habit of giving to the people whatever we have for the sake of Allah (SWT) is always an amazing act for us and our success because the act of giving always makes you happier and satisfied instead of taking.

4. Believe in Revelation

The fourth important aspect, we should believe in what have been revealed to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and before Him (PBUH). In [Surah Nisa 4:113], Allah (SWT) says: We have revealed to you: The Book and the wisdom (Hikmah). So, it's clear that by the Book He means Qur'an and wisdom (Hikmah) lies in Prophet's acts and the Sunnah. We need to believe in what has been revealed by Allah (SWT) to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Allah (SWT) revealed the Holy Quran to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), which is the word of wisdom and a proof of the Divine Message. Quran is safe and secure as it was revealed while the other revealed Books were found altered. Among the books considered to be revealed, the four mentioned by name in the Quran are the Tawrat (Torah) revealed to Prophet Musa (Moses) (AS), the Zabur revealed to Prophet Dawud (David) (AS), the Injil (Gospel) revealed to Prophet Isa Jesus) (AS), and the Quran revealed to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). We must follow the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) in every matter. The Prophet Mohammad's (PBUH) actions and everything revealed in the Qur'an are worth believing and worth following for us. The first ever verse revealed was 'Iqra' that means Read, which indicates that education is mandatory for every man and woman. Moreover, everyone must have to seek the beneficial knowledge not for the harmful knowledge.

5. **The Undoubted Faith (Yaqeen)**

The fifth important aspect mentioned in these verses (ayaats) is the undoubted faith. There are three steps of, Ilm-Ul-yaqeen (Faith gained by knowledge of something), Ain-Ul-yaqeen (Faith gained by seeing something) and Haq-Ul-yaqeen (Faith gained by experience of something). For example, if someone tells you that there is a fire on the mountain, you may believe in, but by seeing this scene with your eyes will make your belief stronger. If you go to the place of fire and feel the warmth and burning of fire, its flames, the burnt down dust, burnt down trees or place and another loses, it will make your belief stronger to its limit because you have experienced it. Therefore, Allah (SWT) mentioned in Qur'an, people will attain the Haq-Ul-yaqeen in the Hereafter. It is also mentioned that the remembrance of the hereafter, changes the human behavior more rapidly than anything else. The belief that we are accountable for our deeds and imagining the sufferings of the fire, helps us to change our hostile behavior. When we will have yaqeen (Faith) in Hereafter, our behavior will change automatically.

It is told that the people who will attain all five characteristics in them, they will be the most guided and the most successful people as mentioned in [Surah Al-Baqarah 2:5]. Allah (SWT) has exalted these people higher in this world and the Hereafter. As Allah (SWT), has mentioned in Surah [Al-Talaq 65:2-3], who has forbearance (Taqwa), Allah (SWT) will remove all his difficulties, Allah (SWT) will provide him sustenance in the world from those sources he would have never imagined of them. Finally, Allah (SWT) will be sufficient for him.

Other Perspective Discuss in Surah Al-Baqarah

- **The Jews**

Polytheists (mushrikeen) at Makkah were ignorant of Islam, but in Madinah Jews were the people who had the revelation by the Prophet Musa (AS). They were initially Muslims, but they not only altered their book and its messages, but also adopted the name of "Jew" instead of Muslim. They were quite aware of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) but denied His (PBUH) very presence and they rather turned to enmity with Him (PBUH). That is the reason of one third of the Surah has addressed the Israelis. This added a critical review of their history, their moral degeneration and their religious perversions.

- **Rules and Regulations**

After the establishment of a Muslim state in Madinah, Quran guided about social, cultural, economic, political and legal problems and their solutions. The half part of this Surah deals with those principles and regulations which are essential for the integration and solidarity of a community and for the solution of community problems. The rules and regulations have been laid down for their organization and social, economic, political and international problems; on the other hand, drinking, gambling, lending money on interest etc., have been prohibited to keep the Muslims safe from bad deeds. Some instructions are given for day-to-day activities.

- **Stories of the Prophets**

The Quran is a book of guidance and invites human to believe in Allah (SWT), Prophet-hood, and Life-after-death. Allah (SWT) invites mankind to accept the Guidance voluntarily and to submit before Allah (SWT). The event of Prophet Adam (AS) shows that the only right thing for them is to accept and follow the Guidance. This event also tells that the Guidance of Islam is the same as was given to Prophet Adam (AS). The events of Prophet Ibrahim (AS) and Prophet Musa (AS) also indicate that Allah (SWT) is quite able to resurrect the dead ones and to call them to account for their deeds.

- **Change of Qiblah**

The declaration of the change of "qiblah" from Bait ul Maqdas (Jerusalem) to the Ka`abah (Makkah) is a symbol of the change of leadership from Israel to the Muslim Community. Salat (Prayer), Fast, Zakat, Haj, and Jihad have been made mandatory for the moral training of the Muslim community. The Surah ends with a prayer which is needed by the Muslim Community all the time.

Surah Al-Asr

Introduction

This is 103 Surah of the Holy Quran which revealed in Makkah. This Surah is among of the most comprehensive Surah's of the Quran because it states the minimum criteria required for the divine success for the human. Imam Asha'fi said if Allah (SWT) would have revealed only this surah instead of whole Quran, this surah would have been enough for the guidance of the humanity.

Its translation is as given:

"By the Time, Verily Man is in loss, except those who believe and do righteous good deeds, and recommend one another to the truth and recommend one another to the patience."

The Explanation of Swear of Time

In general, we swear to fortify our viewpoint. Ibnu Qayyum says whenever Allah (SWT) swears of something, He doesn't only mean to make something honored (Moazzam) but also a means of a reply. When you swear, you have to answer or reply to what you swear by.

In this verse, Allah (SWT) swears by Time. Allah (SWT) swears sometimes to strengthen His verses. He sometimes uses the names of His creatures when He pledges to indicate the importance and value of these creatures to mankind. Moreover, we see in the Quran:

I swear by the city (Makkah); [Al-Balad 90:1]

and

By the fig, and the olive, [At-Tin: 95:1]

So here in this verse, Allah (SWT) has revealed the importance of Time to make us understand that every moment of time is significant for us to attain success.

Asr means "declining day" or "fleeting away". The word "Aseer" refers to all types of juices. At that very time of the day when it is going to an end, it looks like it squeezes itself, as just after these moments a new day gets its start with the call of Maghrib (adhan –e-Maghrib). So this portion of time has its own importance because before the day is finished, few moments are left, and Allah (SWT) swears that all mankind is in the loss, not only in this world but also in the Hereafter. This surah not only refers to the people who have wasted their time and passed their lives in ignorance but also to the people who valued time, but the salvation for all humanity comes only when they will have strong faith in Allah (SWT) and do righteous

deeds and invite others to join in with us in righteous deeds and also towards the ultimate truth (Haq) and patience.

Hazrat Abu Huraira (RA) reported: I heard Allah (SWT) 's Messenger (PBUH) as saying: Allah (SWT), the Exalted and Glorious, said: The son of Adam abuses Dahr (the time), whereas I am Dahr since in My hand are the day and the night. (Muslim #5580)

In the last verse, some exceptions are mentioned about the people who are safe. Allah (SWT) indicated the conditions upon which our success and failure depend.

“Except those who believe and do good works, and enjoin one another to truth and patience.”

[Al-Asr 103:3]

The first important condition is the Belief. Faith in Allah (SWT) and His Attributes as a single entity, without any other condition. The Articles of Faith that every Muslim must uphold and apply whatever they entail. These articles comprise in general the elements of the Beliefs (Aqeedah).

The Levels of the Deen

Hazrat Umar bin al-Khattab (RA) said: While we were sitting with the Messenger of Allah (PBUH), one day, a man appeared in very white clothes with very black hair. He did not seem to be a transient, yet none of us recognized him. He came in and sat facing the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), with his knees touching the Prophet's Mohammad (PBUH), knees, and placed his hands on the thighs of the Prophet Mohmmad (PBUH), and said, '0, Mohammad (PBUH)! Tell me, what is Islam?' The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), answered, 'Islam is to testify that there is no true god except Allah (SWT), and Mohammad (PBUH) is the Messenger of Allah (SWT), perform the Salah, give the Zakat, observe Fasting of Ramadhan, and perform the Hajj if you can afford it.' The man said, 'You have told the truth.' Hazrat umar (RA) said, we were amazed; he asked him and yet he approved his answer.'

The man further asked, 'Tell me what is Eman (Faith)?' The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), said, 'Eeman is to believe in Allah (SWT), and to believe in His angels, His Books, His Messengers, and to believe in the Final Day, and in the al-Qadar and in its good & bad consequences.' 'You have told the truth,' he said.

Then he asked, 'Tell me, what is Ihsan?' Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, 'It is to worship Allah (SWT) as though you see Him. Although you do not see Him, yet He sees you.'

He said, 'Tell me, when is the Final Hour?' The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), said, 'The one who is asked has no more knowledge about its timing than the one who is asking.'…. Then the man left. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), was thinking for a while, and then he asked Hazrat Umar (RA), 'Do you know who the questioner was?' Hazrat Umar (RA) said 'Allah (SWT) and His Messenger know best,' Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said. 'That was Jibreel (AS). He came to teach you your Deen.,"

According to the hadith there are three levels in the Deen: Islam, Eeman and Ihsan.

Islam

The first level is known as Islam, which is based on five pillars, they are, The Testimony of Faith (there is no true God except Allah (SWT) and Mohammad (PBUH) is the Messenger of Allah (SWT) that man must announce to enter Islam, performing Salah, giving Zakat, observing Ramadhan and performing Hajj once in a lifetime for those who can afford it.

Emaan

Emaan is the second level, which consists of six articles. A Muslim must believe in

1-Allah (SWT)
2- His Angels
3- His Scriptures
4- His Messengers
5- The Last Day
6- The Divine Decree (Taqdeer).

Ihsan

Ihsan means worshipping Allah (SWT), as though one sees Him; that is, a Muslim must be conscious of Allah (SWT) and should know that He sees him wherever he may be. This is the best and highest level a Muslim can reach. It can be said that not every Muslim is Mu'min (a believer) and not every believer is a Muhsin· (who has reached the level of Ihsan). The second condition is to perform righteous deeds.

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: Righteousness is good behavior, and sin is what fluctuates in your chest, and you would hate that the people discovered it about you. (Jami at-Tirmidhi, Vol 4, Book 10, Hadith 2389)

It is a divine warning to Muslims, to support their belief with devotion and acts of worship. The Righteous deeds indicate the depth of someone's faith. In the Quran, Allah (SWT) informs us about the various kinds of righteous deeds. To talk about Islam and get a better understanding of the Quran, being kind and dutiful to parents, solving every kind of personal and social problem of others are all considered as the important righteous deeds.

The most important condition for a deed to be righteous is sincerity that is to expect only Allah's pleasure. The intention should be pure and it should not be to seek material benefits or to gain appreciation for the human. It should be kept in mind that Allah (SWT) is absolutely independent of us, whereas we are dependent on Allah (SWT).
The third important condition is to encourage one another to assist and flock towards ultimate truth and patience. We should promote a society where people help each other and look after the interest of others. The righteous deeds and their relationship with the belief lead you and other members of the society in general towards Allah (SWT) and this will lead the humanity towards the ultimate goals of humanity. This is why the Prophet Mohammad(PBUH) has re-enforced this several times: "The best among you are those who are morally sound from others."

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)

Allah (SWT) has sent a manual for mankind in the form of the Holy Quran. When we follow the manual, our lives remain smooth, but when we refuse to follow it then our lives begin to malfunction. As a result, we face difficulties and problems. In this instance, we ask this question to God, "Why Me"? And the simple answer to that is you are not following the manual.

Allah (SWT) in the Quran says, "Whatever misfortune befalls you, it is because of what your hands have earned and Allah (SWT) pardons much". Allah (SWT) commands us to follow His rules along with the reasons and benefits of following those rules. For example, about Salah (prayer) 5 times a day, Allah (SWT) said in the Quran,

"Prayer, it prevents you from evil and bad deeds." [Surah Ankaboot: 45]

So, if our prayers are not preventing us from evil deeds, then there must be something wrong with our prayers.

Similarly, Allah (SWT) says about fasting,

"Fasting has been prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you so that you may become people of piety or righteous". [Surah Al-Baqarah: 183]

In our lives, we have been through two different things: One is test and the other is punishment. We face punishment due to our own sins and face tests to raise our status. Because of those tests, sometimes we get closer to Allah (SWT) and sometimes astray from Him while there is no greater punishment than this. Wealth, children, health, etc. are tests from Allah (SWT) that whether you use them in their real means (prescribed by Allah (SWT)) or in disobeying Him.

Allah (SWT) has put tranquility in the hearts of momineen (pious people) regardless of the external chaos or factors. Increase dosage of worship can scrub sins from our hearts and a time would come where we could taste the "halawatul Iman" the sweetness of faith, where the act of worship itself becomes sweet. Some scholars say that sometimes people worship to please Allah (SWT) while some people do acts of worship for Jannah. Both acts have permissible as Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) himself prayed to God, "O Allah (SWT) save from the hell-fire.".

While some people perform acts of worship because they love to do so. They find immense pleasure in worship. As Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, ***"The coolness of my eyes is in Salah (prayer)"***.

Non-Muslims' Views about Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)

- Michael H. Hart, a Jewish historian listed Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) as the first most influential person in his book, "The Most Influential persons in Human History". He stated further, "My choice of Mohammad (PBUH) to lead the list of the world's most influential persons may surprise some readers and may be questioned by others, but He was the only man in history who was supremely successful on both the religious and secular level".
- Mahatma Gandhi when closed the second volume of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s biography he said, "I was sorry there was not more for me to read of that great life".
- As per the opinion of George Bernard Shaw, "I have always held the religion of Mohammad (PBUH) in high estimation because of its wonderful vitality. It is the only religion which appears to me to possess that assimilating capacity to the changing phase of existence which can make itself appeal to every age. I have studied him – the wonderful man and in my opinion, far from being an anti-Christ, He (Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)) must be called the savior of humanity".
- Malcom X said, "Try to defame Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is just like spitting on the Sun".
- Thomas Carlyle said, "The lies (Western slander) which well-meaning zeal has heaped around this man (Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)) are disgraceful to ourselves only".
- W. Montgomery Watt wrote books about Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). He said, "to suppose Mohammad (PBUH) an impostor raises more problem that it solves".
- As per the opinion of Dr. William Draper, four years after the death of Justinian, A.D. 569, was born in Makkah, in Arabia, the man who, of all men, has exercised the greatest influence upon the human race…. To be the religious head of many empires, to guide the daily life of one-third of the human race, may perhaps justify the title of a messenger of God.
- Alphonse de LaMartaine praised Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) in such a manner, "If greatness of purpose, the smallness of means, and astonishing results are the three criteria of a human genius, who could dare compare any great man in history with Mohammad (PBUH)? The most famous men created arms, laws and empires only. They founded, if anything at all, no more than material powers which often crumbled away before their eyes. This man moved not only armies, legislation, empires, peoples, dynasties, but millions of men in one-third of the then inhabited world; and more than that, he moved the altars, the gods, the religions, the ideas, the beliefs, and the souls".
- Leo Tolstoy said, "Mohammad (PBUH) has always stood higher than the Christianity. He does not consider God as a human being and never makes himself equal to God. Muslims worship nothing except God and Mohammad (PBUH) is his messenger. There is not any mystery and secret in it."
- And finally, Allah (SWT) said, "We have exalted your mention and your mention will always remain."

Allah (SWT) promised the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) that "I will make your zikr (remembrance) high".

"Allah (SWT) and Angels, they send peace and blessings upon Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), O you who believe you should also send peace and blessings upon Prophet (PBUH)". [Surah Al-Ahzaab: 56]

One of the best dua (prayer) is to send blessings upon Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). There is a Sahih Hadith that once a person came to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and said, "Ya Rasool Allah, when I make dua (prayer) I praise Allah (SWT) and then send peace and blessings upon you while peace and blessings upon you is one-fourth (1/4) of my dua (prayer)." Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "If you do more than that then what is the harm in it? He said, "Okay, Ya Rasool Allah I will do one-third (1/3)." Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "What if you do more than that". He said, "Ya Rasool Allah I will do half (1/2) of my dua (prayer) as peace and blessings upon you". Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "What if you do more than that". He said, "Ya Rasool Allah, I will ask no dua (prayer) except sending peace and blessings upon you" Then Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "If you will do that Allah (SWT) will fulfill your wishes even without asking."

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is the best creation of Allah (SWT). Allah (SWT) says,

"His (Prophet) example is the best one". [Surah Al-Ahzaab:21]

Allah (SWT) has used the word "Azeem" for the character of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). At another place, Allah (SWT) says, "Who-so-ever obeys Allah (SWT) and the Messenger, He will have tremendous success." A success whose attributes will be Azeem. Scholars perceived it as you will get success both in this life and after death.

Now, as we have built our foundation on three principles, Belief in Allah (SWT), Belief in His Messenger (PBUH), Belief in His Book. Now a question comes, Is Islam rational or blind following? The answer is, it is both at the same time. Quran continuously pointed towards Aaqil (wise), those who think, those who observe, reflect, ponder and see. Why? So, that you could come to the realization that Allah (SWT) is the truth; the Quran is the word of God and Mohammad (PBUH) is the last Prophet of Allah (SWT). So now, there is no choice but to obey Allah (SWT).

The Life of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and Pluralism

Introduction

We have discussed in detail about the life of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) in Makkah and Madinah. We will now discuss His life regarding tolerance, which is also known as pluralism. Pluralism is defined as a social organization in which diversity of racial or religious or ethnic or cultural group is tolerated. It shows that we must develop a level of tolerance for those people who have different views and opinions than us. Although Islam talks about such issues in detail and on the other hand, there are some certain fundamental foundations on which it does not compromise.

Propaganda

"Propaganda came in the twentieth century. The development of mass and multi-media offered a fertile ground for propaganda. And global conflict provided the impetus need for its growth". (Propaganda, power, and persuasion). The propaganda was used to spread different point of views regardless of truth or falsehood to make other people believe in it. In the first and the second world war, Germans and Russians did propaganda against each other effectively. In the modern world, the importance of propaganda has increased greatly due to the emergence of more advanced and easily accessible modes of mass-communication. People start believing in it whatever news is needed to propagate via this modern media regardless of the sanctity of the news.

Muslims in the Media

Muslims are propagated in the media as non-tolerant people in the world. They are the people to destroy you. They are also known by these names like terrorists, fundamentalists, extremists, etc. They are Islamic terrorists as propagated by today's powerful media. Whereas it is noted that 87.5 million people are war dead for politically motivated reasons in the 20th century. ***(Out of Control: Global Turmoil on the eve of 21st century).*** These wars were not fought for any religious reasons, but they were for political and local reasons. In the above-mentioned book, they termed the 20th century as the bloodied century full of conflicts and blood.

The Life of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)

Under Islamic rule, it was the most prosperous time for the Jews, which was known as their golden age. Muslims were also very prosperous and advanced in knowledge at that time. Later, Christians came and they killed the Jews and Christians.
Tolerance were an inherent aspect of Islamic Andalusian society. ***(Maria Rose Menocal)***. This shows that Islam as a very tolerant society. In the life of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), the Jews were given the equal rights to live in peace. The reason is mentioned in the Quran,

"And We have not sent you (O Mohammad (PBUH) except as a mercy to the worlds.". [Al-Anbiya: 107].

A camel cried and complained Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) of his master for overburdening. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) called his master and instructed him to remain merciful with animals. The companions made a pulpit for the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) to address on it.

A tree began to cry and He (PBUH) had to make the tree stop crying, Actually, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) had used to take back support with the tree before the pulpit and later the tree missed the chance to serve the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Therefore, the tree cried to express its feelings.

After turning from a Ghazwa, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) saw a restless bird, He (PBUH) directed his companions to put his eggs back to its nest to make him in peace. This shows the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) was how much merciful even with the animals and birds. At the heart of Islam, there is a great mercy, tolerance, and love in it.

The Quran says,

"And verily, You (O Mohammad (PBUH) are on an exalted (standard of) character." [Al-Qalam: 4]

In His (PBUH) life, He (PBUH) had never retaliated with someone for personal reasons, but when someone would break the Islamic law, He (PBUH) would have retaliated. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) even forgave the killer of Hazrat Hamza (RA) (the uncle of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)). The killer embraced Islam later on, but the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) behind the tree.

The Spread of Islam in Java

No warrior reached to Java to embrace them, Islam. There were traders who reached out Indonesia (Java) and they made fair trades with the locals and would pray at the right times and their conduct influenced the locals to embrace Islam. Those Muslims were so upright and honest that the locals followed them without any war and blood. It's very important for every Muslim to adopt such high values and conduct in his own life that other people get influenced by our character and follow us. Similarly, a bad conduct of a Muslim will not only disgrace other Muslims, but also that particular individual Muslim.

If a person wants to see Islam in its true letter and spirit, he must have to examine those people who practice Islam in their life like the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and His Family members , His Companions and people who came after them. Therefore, we should follow Islam in our lives to inspire others towards Islam as role models. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said*,* "O people your Lord is One and your father is One. There is no superiority of an Arab over a Non-Arab or of a Non-Arab over an Arab, or of a white man over a black man, or of a black man over a white man, except in terms of taqwa (piety)". ***(Masnad Ahmad 23489).***

There is no gender or tribal discrimination in Islam. Although, if someone is high in ranks near Allah (SWT) is due to his piety. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "Whoever kills a non-Muslim (living under Islamic rule) will never smell the fragrance of paradise, although its fragrance may be detected from a distance of forty years". ***(Bukhari).*** In another Hadith, "None of you truly believes until he loves for his brothers what he loves for himself". ***(Bukhari and Muslim).***

This means we should not give cheap and poor things to charity. We should give things with good conditions in charity. Charity is not for those people, but for Allah (SWT). Hazrat Ayesha (RA) usually sprayed perfume on what she used to give as charity. Our main job is to spread the message of Islam very clearly and beautifully. We cannot force anyone to embrace Islam.

Gentleness

Hazrat Ayesha (RA) narrated: The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, O Ayesha! Allah (SWT) is gentle and He loves gentleness, and He gives due to the gentleness and does not give due to the harshness and He does not give upon anything else besides it. ***(Muslim 6601).***

Once few Jews showed up and said (God forbid) As'sam-o-Alaikum (death be upon you) to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), to which he replied as same to you. Hazrat Ayesha (RA) infuriatedly cursed the Jews. the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said the above hadith and said that Allah (SWT) would accept my prayers for them but not their prayers for me.

In Surah Al- Kafiroon, Allah (SWT) mentioned the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) to say to the disbelievers I would not worship whom you worship. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said the companions to stay different from Jews and Christians.

In order to be tolerant, you must not leave your own religion. You must have to spread the message of Allah (SWT) to them. You stay on your religion and let them stay on theirs. Allah (SWT) said,

"O mankind, fear your Lord, who created you from one soul, and created from it its mate and dispersed from both of them many men and women. And fear Allah (SWT), through whom you ask one another, and the wombs. Indeed Allah (SWT) is over, over you, an Observer." [Al-Nisa: 1].

Some Important Points

- There is no compromise on the oneness of Allah (SWT). There is only one higher power that is Allah (SWT).
- Islam is a universal religion, there were a lot of companions who were not only Arabs but from different races and color. Islam is not for a particular set of people, but for all humanity.
- The Islam is a complete picture of ultimate tolerance and patience
- We should propagate tolerance from our own character to the world

Seerat un Nabi (PBUH) – Part A
Makki Period

Seerah

In the Arabic language, the word ***"seerah"*** comes from the verb ***"saara"*** (imperfect yaseeru), which means to travel or to be on a journey. A person's seerah is that person's journey through life. It is the story of the person's birth, the events surrounding it, his life and his death, and his manners and characteristics.

Literal Meaning of 'Seerah'

In Islamic sciences or the shariah, "seerah" means the study of the life of the Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), the last and final Prophet and the messenger of Allah (SWT). It is the study of his life and all that is related to him. The information related to him would be like the events and aspects surrounding his biography. This would include knowledge of events that preceded his birth, his interactions and dealings with his companions, his family, the people around him, and the events that occurred shortly after his death.

Seerat un Nabi (PBUH)

The achievements and life of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) cannot be discussed in a lecture or two, however, we can try to briefly discuss the life events of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) by dividing it into two periods.

1. Makki Period
2. Madani Period

Makki Period

The period of Prophet Mohammad's (PBUH) life before the migration (Hijrat) from Mecca to Madinah is called the Makki Period.

The brief description of his Makki period of life is discussed below:

1. Childhood

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), son of Hazrat Abdullah was born in the 6th century. He was born in 570 in Mecca. His father died before his birth. At the age of six, his mother Hazrat

Amna passed away and later his grandfather. Then his uncle looked after him. It proves that his believes were not molded by a single person.

He was sent to the rural area of his upbringing and nursing as per the custom of Arab. At that time, people sent their children to rural areas for two reasons; first for pure air and climate for better growth of their children, second for seeking pure language.

2. Youth & Marriage

As a young boy, He worked as a shepherd. This was significant, as He noted much later, "All the prophets of God were shepherds." He started trading in his youth and earned great respect and the titles of "Truthful One" and "Honest". He was widely valued for his integrity and sincerity. So, Hazrat Khadija (RA) heard about his fame as Sadiq and Ameen and asked him to trade for her. Due to his honesty, she made a huge profit. She was very inspired by Him and proposed Him through a relative. At that time, she was 40 and the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) was 25 years old.

Hazrat Khadija (RA) was very wealthy and contributed her all wealth and support to the growth and strengthening of Islam.

3. Prophethood

He was not convinced by the polytheistic Arab customs and never participated in adultery. He was more concerned with social malicious practices such as the ill-treatment of women, widespread alcoholism, constant warfare and subjugation of the poor. He started going into a cave (Hira) for meditation.

During 610, when he was 40, one night, Allah (SWT) sent an angel Gabriel with divine revelation, that was ***"Iqra"*** (Read).

After the revelation, Hazrat Khadija (RA) took him to her cousin Warqa bin Nofal who was a Christian priest. He said to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) that if I would live long enough to see you become a prophet of Allah (SWT) then I will join you.

This important event was the start of his Prophethood which transformed his life entirely. Afterward, he spent all his life to make people worship only to Allah (SWT).

Soon after the declaration of Prophethood to his relatives, everyone became enemies of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) except few near ones, even uncles of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) Abu Lahab and Abu jehal were so against him that the Quran had to say about Abu Lahab:

"May the hands of Abu Lahab be ruined, and ruined is he". [Surah Al-Masad:1]

Allah (SWT) said to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) in the Quran:

you who covers himself [with a garment]

Arise and warn.

And your Lord glorify [Surah Al-Muddaththir:1-3]

He started working to establish righteousness and piety. His efforts were to remove social evils, to cease the inhabitant of Mecca from their worship of idols and to affirm the Oneness of Allah (SWT). He warned them about the Day of Judgement, accountability of their wrong deeds and the charm of paradise for the pious.

4. Difficulties / Hardships

The Makkans were not ready to accept these reforms because by doing this there socioeconomic and political status was at risk. Few of them among non-believers were convinced in their heart e.g. Abu Jahal, but they refused to accept the divine light for the sake of a worldly affair. They became harsh and inhuman to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and His followers. The new Muslims were often subjected to abuse and maltreatment. Hazrat Sumayyah bint Khabbab (RA) and her husband Hazrat Yasir Ben Amir (RA) were tortured so much that Hazrat Sumayyah (RA) lost her life. She was the first martyr for Islam. Hazrat Bilal (RA) and Hazrat Khabbab ibn al-Aratt (RA) were tortured for the same reason.

Abu Lahab's wife Umme Jamil would regularly dump filth outside the door of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s house.

When Islam began to spread the Makkans asked Abu Talib, the uncle, and protector of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), to hand him over to them for execution but he steadfastly refused.

5. Journey of Ta'if

Initially, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) confined his preaching to natives of Mecca where he could find only 170 people during the first ten years after the declaration of his Prophethood. During 619 when his uncle Abu Talib ibn 'Abd al-Muttalib and his loving wife Hazrat Khadija (RA) died, (it is called "Year of Sorrow"), Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) realized that there was no hope left for the Makkans to accept his religion, he visited the sister city of Ta'if, for the preaching of Islam. He could express his views in the beginning, but shortly the people of Ta'if rejected him and his preaching. They ordered their children and young ones to throw rocks and stones at Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and Hazrat Zayd ibn Harithah (RA) (his companion) to make them leave the city and never come back. Throwing rocks and stones made them bleed. Both were wounded and bleeding as they left Ta'if behind them. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) bled so profusely from the stoning that his feet became clotted to his shoes.

6. She'eb Abi Talib

The Quraish held a meeting and decided to outcast the Banu Hashim and Banu al-Muttalib by placing them under a total social boycott. The other clans from the Quraish would not marry their daughters, transact business with them, keep company with them, nor would they accept any peace overtures from these two clans until they handed over the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).
Banu Hashim and Banu al-Muttalib were forced to leave Mecca and live in She'eb Abi Talib in a miserable condition. They stayed there for about three years until a group of open-minded people headed by Hisham ibn 'Amr contacted some men of the Quraish to cancel the boycott.

7. Migration to Yathrib

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and His small group of followers suffered persecution for 13 years in Mecca. Eventually, in 622 they were forced to leave Mecca and migrate to Yathrib (Medinah), a city whose people eagerly welcomed them.

[i]More information can be taken from the reference books.

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[i] ***Ar-Raheeq al-Makhtoom*** **– "The Sealed Nectar" by S. Mubarakpuri**
"When the moon split" – by S. Mubarakpuri

Seerat un Nabi (PBUH) – Part B
Madani Period

Migration to Madinah

The brutality and maltreatment of Makkans were at their height and they were planning to assassinate Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). After receiving Divine Direction, he along with His companion Hazrat Abu Bakar Siddique (RA) secretly left their homes in Makkah and migrated to Yathrib, which was 320 km north of Makkah. Later, the city was called ***"Madin-tun-Nabi"*** which gradually turned into ***"Madinah".***

The event of Hijra had its importance in Islamic society as the society was turned into an Ummah. The basis of all discrimination, i.e. color, creed, nationality, wealth has vanished. Muslim society was established on equality.

Tribal identification and relation are very important to Arabs. If one's link is broken from the tribe, he becomes a lost person with no reputation. He can be killed by anybody without any accountability. Migration means to cut off themselves from the tribes. This was the greatest sacrifice on the part of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and his followers since anybody could kill them without any fear. They made this sacrifice only to practice Islam.

Miracles During Migration

Many miracles took place during migration, including laying eggs at the door of the cave, spider web, grabbing of Suraqah Bin Maalik by earth, milking of the weak goat of Hazrat Umm-e-Ma'bad (RA) etc. There is an expression about the events in the Quran, Sura Al Toba, Ayat 40.

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) stayed in the cave of Thor (Sour) for about 3 days during his migration to Madinah.

Foundation of Masjid-e-Quba

After eight days' journey, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) stopped on the outskirts of Madinah, called Quba where Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) constructed Masjid-e-Quba. After a few days, He proceeded to Madinah. It was 622, and the Muslim calendar started from the same event.

Threats to Mission of Islam and A New State

Mostly people were cultivators in Madinah except Jews who had three tribes who were powerful traders. People were divided into three groups: Jews, non-Muslim Arabs, and

Muslims. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) constituted peace and unity among the communities of Madinah. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) generated a relationship between the immigrants from Makkah (known as Muhajirin) and Madinites (known as the Ansar, the helpers).

This helped the Ansaar to learn Islam quickly from Muhajirin as they learned in 13 years from the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) in Makkah.

There were few threats to the new Islamic society at that time. Few of them are discussed below:

1. The Hypocrites

A truce was to develop between the two tribes of Madinah (Aus and Khazrij) by a person named Abdullah Ibne Ubayy. He was somehow considered respectable by these two tribes and expected to be the leader of Madinah while suddenly Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) came there and He became the leader of Madinah as He was the Prophet of Allah, so Abdullah Ibne Ubay envy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and therefore he became the leader of the hypocrites (Raees ul Munafiqeen).

Instead of accepting Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) as a leader, he accepted Islam just from the surface, but his heart was always against Islam and in planning with Jews to destroy it. Thus, ayahs in Surah Al-Munafiqoon and Surah Al-Baqarah came to describe the issue of hypocrisy.

2. Three Jewish Tribes

Jews were also settled in Madinah. Since ages, Jews were waiting for a prophet. They heard that the new prophet will be in the land of Arab so they started gathering there from Jerusalem. They were thinking that the prophet will be appointed from their clan and they were used to threat different tribes of Madinah (Aus and Khazrij who had a fight among themselves since generations) to destroy them with the help of that prophet.

So, as soon as they heard that the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is appointed from the Arabs, they started to oppose him.

One of the wives of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) named Hazrat Safiya (RA) was actually the daughter of the Jew leader of a clan. She later told the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) that when You came to Madinah for the first time, my father and my uncle went to see You and to find You that are You really a Prophet of Allah? They saw all the signs in You which were mentioned in our book.

They came back and my uncle asked my father, “Is He the messenger of Allah?”. My father said, “Yes, He is”. My Uncle asked, “How sure are you?”, My father said, “I am 100% sure” then he asked, “What we are going to do now?” and then my father replied, “By Allah, we will oppose him till the day we die”.

There were 3 Jewish tribes in Madinah at that time.

- Banu Nazeer
- Banu Qurayza
- Banu Qaynuqa

The Charter of Madinah (Meesaaq e Madinah), First Written Constitution

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) laid down the foundation of an Islamic state by forming a treaty between Muslims, non-Muslim Arabs, and Jews of Madinah. After assuming a significant role in Madinah, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) recognized a few pressing needs, which included:

- Determining the rights and responsibilities of the local population as well as the immigrants from Makkah
- Making agreements with the non-Muslim population of Madinah, especially the Jews, to ensure peace and harmony
- Creating a strategy and plan to defend the city against invasions
- Making resources available for the immigrants to make a living

This charter contains 47 clauses, which laid the foundations of a sovereign nation-state comprising of Muslims, Jews and Pagans, having equal rights and responsibilities under a common citizenship.

The salient features of this charter include:

- All parties included in the charter, i.e. Muslims, people of the book (Jews and Christians) and pagans, had freedom to practice their religion
- All citizens of the state had equal rights and responsibilities and were protected against excess and oppression
- A system of financial aid was developed within each tribe and between tribes. Communal funds were set up which were used in times of financial need such as to pay ransom or blood-money
- In the event of a war or hostile attack from outsiders on one tribe, all tribes of Madinah (signatories of the charter) were required to come to the aid of the defending tribe.
- In the event of a dispute among the signatories, Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) was the final authority for settling the dispute.
- The *Quraysh* of Makkah were to be boycotted commercially by all signatories and nobody was to extend any support to them

This was the first written constitution of a State set down by the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) of Islam where social insurance was introduced.

But the tribe Banu Qurayza broke the trust as they went to the Quraysh and had a deal with them to support them in attacking the Muslims. Hence, the contract then was nullified.

Major Battles

As a result of breaking the contract by Jews and the conspiracies of non-believers of Makkah, few battles took place. A brief detail is discussed under.

- Battle of Badr 624 (Ramadan, 2 AH)
- Battle of Uhud 625 (Shawwal, 3 AH)
- Battle of the Trench (Khandak) 627 (Shawwal, 5 AH)

1. Battle of Badr

In this Battle, the Muslims army were only 313 in number and non-believers of Makkah were about 1000 in number. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) made a dua to Allah (SWT), "O Allah please help us in this, as if we are gone then there will be no one to worship you". And as a result, Allah (SWT) sent 1000 angels, rank after rank as mentioned in surah Al-Anfaal, how those angels came down to help them.

2. Battle of Uhud

In this battle, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) commanded some of his men to stand as archers and not to leave their posts, but those people when saw that the battle is almost over, left their positions and they came to collect the bounty of the war. At that time, Hazrat Khalid bin Waleed (RA) who then was a non-Muslim told his army that top post is empty. So, the non-believers turned around and re-attacked the Muslims.

This happened due to the disobedience of the order of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

Hazrat Hamza (RA), uncle of Prophet (PBUH) was martyred in this battle.

3. Battle of Trench

Hazrat Salman Farsi (RA) proposed the idea of digging a trench to fight with the army of non-believers as they were great in number because he had seen this war tactic in Persia. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) accepted his suggestion and hence Muslims won the battle.

Treaty of Hudaybiyyah **(628 (Dhu al-Qa'dah, 6 AH)**

Six years after Hijra, in 628 CE, the Prophet Mohammad (peace be upon him) dreamt that he and his followers were entering Makkah and performing Tawaf. It was a good sign and hence He declared His plan to visit Makkah to perform Umrah.

Over 1,400 Muslims donned ihram with him from Madinah. They took 70 camels with them for sacrifice. As per the established practice, the Makkans were bound to allow pilgrims coming, but without arms to perform Umrah. But, alarmed by the huge Muslim presence, the Quraysh leaders decided not to allow them from entering the city and sent Khaled Bin Walid with 200 fighters to stop them defying the centuries-old Arab tradition.

The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) changed the route of Taneem to avoid confrontation and came to a lesser-known place called Hudaibiyah on the western edge of the city.

Determined not to allow Muslims to enter the city, the Makkans sent Urwah bin Masud to negotiate with the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Highly impressed with the scenes of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s love among His followers, Urwah said, "I have visited the royal courts of the Persians, Roman, and Ethiopian kingdoms, but I have never seen the kind of respect and high esteem as the followers of Mohammad have for him. They have come only for worship. Let them enter the holy city." But the Makkan leaders were bent upon preventing the Muslims.

The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) later sent Hazrat Uthman bin Affan (RA) who had good contacts in Makkah, but they detained him and spread a rumor to upset the Muslims that Hazrat Uthman (RA) has been killed. This was a great challenge. Though 400 km away from His city and having no proper arms to fight, He prepared for a warlike situation and called His followers to prepare for a fight until death. The people rushed to take an oath of allegiance on His pious hand and within a brief time, the news reached Makkah that 1400 volunteers were ready to fight until death. This broke their morale and Makkans agreed to discuss the terms of peace with him.

They released Hazrat Uthman (RA) and sent Sohayl bin Amr Al-Thaqafi to negotiate the terms of peace with the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Sohayl (later embraced Islam) was very tough in dealings.

He reached the following terms:

- In the name of Almighty Allah. These are the conditions of Peace between Mohammad, son of Abdullah and Suhayl ibn Amr the envoy of Makkah.
- There will be no fighting for ten years.
- Anyone who wishes to join Mohammad and to enter into any agreement with him is free to do so. Anyone who wishes to join the Quraysh and to enter into any agreement with them is free to do so.
- A young man, or one whose father is alive, if he goes to Mohammad without permission from his father or guardian, will be returned to his father or guardian. But if anyone goes to the Quraysh, he will not be returned.
- This year the Muslims will go back without entering Makkah. But next year Mohammad and his followers can enter Makkah, spend three days, perform the tawaf. During these three days, the Quraysh will withdraw to the surrounding hills. When Mohammad and his followers enter Makkah, they will be unarmed except for sheathed swords.

Apparently, it was an agreement that went against the wishes of the Muslims, but later it turned out to be a great victory for Muslims. When the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) returned from Hudaibiya, He received the Divine revelation that Almighty Allah (SWT) had put a seal of honor on this treaty and called it "Fatah Al-Mubeen" (Manifest Victory) in the Qur'an. (48:01). The following year when the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) returned to perform Umrah, there

were 2,000 pilgrims with him instead of 1400 earlier. One of the companions Hazrat Abu Zar Ghaffari (RA) accepted Islam along with his family and the whole clan.

Conquest of Makkah 630 (Ramadan, 8 AH)

Both the Muslims and non-believer of Makkah adhered to the treaty initially. However, two years later there was a violation of the agreement. One of the tribes allied with the Makkans attacked and killed some members of a tribe allied with the Muslims. This incident dissolved the treaty.

By this time, the Muslims had become a formidable force and so in 630 C.E. the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) decided to take an army of 10,000 towards Makkah. Once the Muslims had reached Makkah, the leaders of Quraysh surrendered. As a result, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) announced:

"Those who shelter in the Ka'ba are safe; those who shelter in the house of Abu Sufyan are safe, and those who remain confined to their houses are also safe".

The Makkans were afraid about the impending conquest of their city because the Arabs had lived by the law of retaliation and there was a fear that Muslims would take revenge for the persecution of the Muslims and the losses in subsequent battles. When the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and the Muslims entered the area of the Kaaba, He announced clemency to everyone in Makkah who no longer wished to fight the Muslims:

"I speak to you in the same words as Yusuf (AS) spoke to his brothers. This day no reproach shall be on you. God will forgive you; He is the Most Merciful of the Merciful. You can go away!"

Many of the Makkans, who was expecting some sort of punishment, were surprised by the Prophet's Mohammad (PBUH) statement and some decided to become Muslim. Thus, the conquest of Makkah was bloodless and ended years of warfare and violence between Quraysh and the Muslims.

Quran described the conquest of Makkah as:

"Truth has come and falsehood has perished. Surely! Falsehood (by its nature) is bound to perish." [Surah Al-Isra:81]

Completion of Islam and Last Pilgrimage

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) started to prepare for the Hajj in the same year (632) and told everyone to join him. He made his famous speech, known as the Farewell Sermon, to a crowd of over 120,000 companions in the Arafat valley in the afternoon.

In His speech, after praising and thanking Allah (SWT), Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said that all people are servants of Allah (SWT), that they all descended from the same mother and father, all people are equal, regardless of their race, color, language, and class; the measure

of superiority is their piety before Allah (SWT). Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) generally mentioned the human rights. He emphasized the security of life, property, and chastity. He ordered that people should be careful about human rights, avoid cruelty and haram (religiously forbidden) food and protect trusts; he threw light on the mutual rights, obligations, and duties of the husband and wife. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) also stated that all Muslims are brothers and sisters, and he emphasized the importance of unity and cooperation. He ordered people to perform the prayer, fast, pay zakat, and perform Hajj, as well as telling them to obey the moral rules. He mentioned some concepts and traditions from the Age of Ignorance, and he announced that interest and blood feud were now forbidden, and he invalidated the institutions and practices of the Age of Ignorance related to the administration of Makkah and the Kaaba.

He frequently asked, "Have I conveyed the message?" to his Companions to confirm his words. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) ended his sermon by saying, "O Allah, be my witness!

As part of this sermon, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) recited to them a revelation from Allah (SWT), which he had just received, and which completed the Quran, for it was the last passage to be revealed:

"This day have I perfected for you, your religion and fulfilled My favor unto you, and it hath been My good pleasure to choose Islam for you as your religion".
[Surah Al-Maidah:3]

As Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "I may not be able to meet you here again after this year", and died shortly after, this hajj is known as "The Farewell Hajj" and this sermon as "The Farewell Sermon".

[i] More information can be taken from the reference books.

[i] ***Ar-Raheeq al-Makhtoom*** **– "The Sealed Nectar" by S. Mubarakpuri**
"When the moon split" – by S. Mubarakpuri

Hadith

Importance of Hadith

Hadith is a source of Islamic knowledge. We gain our knowledge from the Quran and Sunnah. Allah (SWT) mentioned in the Quran,

'Indeed, it is We who sent down the Qur'an and indeed, we will be its guardian.'
[Surah Al- Hijr:15]

This verse shows that Allah has guarded the zikr of the Quran.

"Allah has sent down to you the Book (The Qur'an), and al-Hikmah, and taught you that which you knew not." [Surah an-Nisa:113]

Above is another verse from Surah An-Nisa regarding Quran and Hikma (Wisdom). Hikma means the Sunnah of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). So, Allah (SWT) has preserved both the Quran and its interpretation.

For example, once Hazrat Umar ibn Khitab (RA) did not have water to perform ablution, he asked the other companions who recited the ayah from the Quran regarding tayamum which he interpreted in a way that he entirely covered himself in the dirt, the way he did tayamum in a way we do ghuls (take a bath), instead doing with water, he did with dirt. When the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) saw him, He (PBUH) said to him, "Umar! What is this?" He said "Ya Rasool Allah (SAW), I am fulfilling the ayah (verse) of the Quran, I am doing tayamum". Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) told him "this is not the way to do tayamum". He (PBUH) then told him the method of tayamum. There are many times when the Sahaba (Companions) (RA) tried to interpret the ayah (verse) of the Quran, but they had to connect themselves back to or reminded about the Sunnah of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

The easy example of Sunnah is the method of prayer or zakat. As the Quran says, "And establish prayer and give zakat and obey the Messenger - that you may receive mercy".

In this ayah (verse), the order to offer prayer and to give Zakat were specified. But the timings, method, and number of prayers, neither of the amount, quantity and procedure of zakat is instructed. So, Sunnah is taken as the source of knowledge along with the Holy book Quran.

Allah (SWT) has revealed unto you (Prophet Mohammad PBUH), Al-Kitab (Book of Allah (SWT), Quran) and Al-Hikma. So here, according to Imam Shafai that there is a consensus of scholars that Hikma is a Sunnah of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Because the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) never saying things out of his account, not declaring things halal or haram by himself as these are revealed to him by Allah (SWT).

In the Quran, Allah (SWT) said,

"Whatever messenger gives you take it and whatever he forbids you leave it and fear Allah because Allah (SWT) is severe in punishment". [Al-Hashr:7]

There is a Sahih hadith where Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said that "I have been given two things, one is the Quran and the other similar to it".

Definition of Hadith

The word Hadith means news, report or narration. In Islamic terminology, the term hadith refers to the sayings, actions and tacit approval or disapproval of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) for any action.

Whatever, Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) did or said, was all under the Divine Guidance and Control. In other words, we can say that Hadith is a Divine Word, but indirectly as compared to the Quran which is directly a Divine word.

Basic Concepts of Hadith

Hadith delivers the following basic concepts.

- The Hadith of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) aids us how to live in this world and how to interact with this world without letting it get into our hearts
- Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) showed and told us the ways of how to worship Allah (SWT)
- How to interact with other people and how to perform daily chores
- He showed us how to live our lives while preparing for hereafter

All these were done to facilitate Muslims. As Hazrat Ayesha (RA) said, "The character of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is the Quran itself." The practical form of the Quran can be seen as a life of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

"Say, [O Muhammad], "If you should love Allah, then follow me, [so] Allah will love you and forgive you your sins. And Allah is Forgiving and Merciful." [Surah Al-Imran:31]

Allah (SWT) wants us to follow the Uswa-e-Hasna (the way of life) of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

Difference between Sunnah and Hadith

The word Sunnah is usually used synonymously with Hadith but usually, Sunnah is used while reporting the deeds of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) whereas the word Hadith is used while reporting the statements of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

But the Sunnah according to the scholar of Islamic jurisprudence means those acts which are not 'farz' (Obligatory). Sunnah is normally known as 'mustahab' (Recommended), something which is recommended, but not mandatory, if you do it you will be rewarded, but if you don't do there is no punishment for that.

As per legal perspective, Sunnah means everything associated with Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), his actions, his speech, his words, his deeds, his silence, his ways which include the hadith as well. Hadith is a carrier of Sunnah.

Biddah

Biddah means that something has never been practiced as an act of worship by Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said one of his sermons, "Indeed the best speech is the book of Allah (SWT) and best guidance is the guidance of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and the worst of all of this are those matters that have newly been introduced in the religion and every new matter introduced into the religion of Islam is biddah and every biddah is going astray and every going astray is in the hellfire.

Parts of Hadith

Each hadith has two parts.

1. Sanad
2. Matan

Sanad (Authenticity)

Sanad is another word being used in relation with Hadith which literally means support and technically means the chain of transmission or chain of narrators or the sequential list of the names of the group of narrators who narrate a particular hadith. So, when we say that a hadith has weak Sanad, it means that there is some weakness found in those people who are reporting it.

There is another division of Hadith on the basis of Sanad.

1. **Marfu'a - Hadith** which Sanad stretches back to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).
2. **Mawqoof - Hadith** which Sanad reaches to the companion of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).
3. **Maqtoo'a -** Hadith where student of the companion of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Tabi' is the end of the Sanad.

For example, this particular Sanad consists of eight names:

- **Muhammad ibn Ismail Bukhari** who heard from, **Al- Humaydi, Abdullah ibn Zubayr** who heard from, **Sufyan** who heard from, **Yahya ibn Said al Ansari** who heard from, **Muhammad ibn Ibrahimm al -Taymi** who heard from, **Alqama ibn Waqas al- Laythi**

who heard from, **Umar ibn al –Khattab (RA)** who heard from Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)

So, chain of narrator is very important for the Sanad of Hadith.

Matan (Text)

The second part of the Hadith consists of words from Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) himself. This is called the matan which means, among other things.

For example, Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "Actions are judged by intentions."

Few authentic Ahadith

- Seeking of Knowledge is an obligation upon every Muslim
- All good deeds are charity (Sadqa)
- Actions are judged by intentions
- Religion is an advice and good counsel
- Modesty (Haya) is part of faith (Emaan)
- Indeed, every religion has innate character and the character of Islam is modesty (haya)

Types of Hadith

There are three basic types of Hadith.

• **Qawli Hadith** - what Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said and spoke himself.
• **Fi'ali Hadith**- The action of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) what he performed and demonstrated.
• **Taqriri Hadith**- which comes from Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s silence regarding any action

There are two kinds of Hadith according to the nature of words of Hadith.

1. Hadith-e-Qudsi

It is that Hadith Which Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) quotes from Allah (SWT). In other words, it is a statement of Allah (SWT) quoted by Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and which is not in the Quran.

2. Hadith Nabawi

It contains the words that Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) spoke himself.

Books of Hadith

1. Jami
It is book of Hadith which contains the Ahadith relevant to all major aspects of life.
For example, Al Jami of Imam Bukhari and Muslim.

2. Sunan
It is a book of Ahadith which contains Ahadith according to the chapters of Fiqh. For Example, sunan of Imam Abu Dawud, Imam Nisai.

3. Musannaf
The kind of work in which the Ahadith are assembled together according to theme is called musannaf, which means divided up because it divides the Ahadith according to the themes.
For example, Musannaf ibn Abi Shaibba, Musannaf Abdul Razzaq.

4. Musnad
Musnad means supported, because it lists the Ahadith under the names of various companions who come last in the transmission chains, the isnad support or guarantee its authenticity. The best example is Ahmad ibn Hanbal work known as Musnad imam Ahamd ibn Hanbal.

Sahih Hadith

SAHIH is that which contains these four qualities

- The chain of Reporters or Narrators is unbroken or uninterrupted from the Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) to the Compiler or Last Reporter (*Ravi*). This means that there should be no gap in the chain of reporters, one connected with the following or next reporter till the last reporter
- Each reporter or narrator of the Hadith must be a person of righteous moral excellence in all his sayings and deeds in all walks of life
- All the reporters must possess healthy retentive memory
- The Hadith reported by him must not be rare or of an uncommon or peculiar nature

Six Authentic Books of Ahadith

Sehah Sittah (The six authentic books of Hadith)

1. Sahih Bukhari
2. Sahih Muslim
3. Sunan Abu-Dawood
4. Sunan Nasai
5. Sunan Tirmidhi
6. Sunan Ibn Majah

Among these, two books are considered as the most authentic books, according to the consensus of scholars which are Sahih Bukhari and Sahih Muslim.

Agreed Upon Hadith / Muttafaqun Alaihi

Muttafaqun Alaihi (متفق عليه) or Agreed Upon Hadith is a Hadith which is found both in Sahih Bukhari as well as in Sahih Muslim is called Muttafaqun Alaihi or Agreed Upon Hadith.

Classification of Hadith

For judgment of reliability of sanad and matan of the Hadith, it is divided into four categories.

1. Sahih Genuine / Authentic

Hadith that passes all the tests and can be regarded without any question coming from the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Each reporter should be trustworthy in his religion; he should be known to be truthful in his narrating and to report the wording of the *hadith* verbatim, not only its meaning.

2. Hasan / Good

Strong Hadith but raising some doubt about the authenticity. It is the one where its source is known and its reporters are unambiguous.

3. Daif / Weak

Hadith that raise many questions about its authenticity. It fails to reach the status of *hasan*. Usually, the weakness is:

a) One of discontinuity in the *isnad*, or
b) One of the reporters having a disparaged character.

4. Maudu

Fabricated or forged: is a hadith whose text goes against the established norms of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s sayings, or its reporters include a liar. Fabricated hadiths are also recognized by external evidence related to a discrepancy found in the dates or times of a particular incident.

Two books are recommended by teacher Lulu wal Marjan and Riaz ul saliheen to study the Hadith.

Pillars of Islam and Articles of Faith

Five Pillars of Islam

The Five Pillars of Islam are the five basic acts in Islam, considered obligatory by Muslims. These are summarized in the famous Hadith of Gabriel. The Quran presents them as a framework for worship and a sign of commitment to the faith. They are

1. Shahadah (Creed)
2. Daily prayers (Salat)
3. Fasting during Ramadan (Sawm)
4. Almsgiving (Zakāt) and
5. Pilgrimage to Makka (Hajj) at least once in a lifetime

1. Shahadah

Shahadah is a saying and confessing monotheism and accepting Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) as God's Messenger. The shahadah is a set statement normally recited in Arabic, which is translated as

I testify and bear witness that there is no god except Allah (SWT), and Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is the last and final messenger of Allah (SWT).

Also, it is said that when dying one should recite this declaration of faith. In Azaan (call to prayer) it is recited. When a person wishes to convert his religion, he should recite this affirmation and believe in it.

2. Salat

Salat is the Islamic prayer. As per Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) the difference between a Muslim and a non-believer is Salat. Now, if you say that you are a Muslim, it is obligatory for you to offer prayers.

Salat consists of five daily prayers: Fajr, Dhuhr, Asr, Maghrib, and Isha'a. Fajr is performed at dawn, Dhuhr is a noon prayer, Asr is performed in the afternoon, Maghrib is the sunset prayer, and Isha'a is the evening prayer. Each prayer consists of a certain amount of rakaʿāt. A prayer either consists of two, three, or four rakaʿāt. All of these prayers are recited while facing the Ka'bah in Makkah. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) told us that the first question on the Day of Judgement will be asked regarding Salat.

3. Sawm

Three types of fasting (Sawm) are recognized by the Quran: ritual fasting, fasting as compensation for repentance (both from Surah Al-Baqarah), and ascetic fasting (from Surah Al-Ahzab).

Ritual fasting is an obligatory act during the month of Ramadan. Muslims must abstain from food, drink, and sexual intercourse from dawn to dusk during this month, and are to be especially mindful of other sins. Fasting is necessary for every Muslim that has reached puberty. The fast is meant to allow Muslims to seek nearness to Allah (SWT), to express their gratitude towards Allah (SWT) and dependence on Him, atone for their past sins, and to remind them of the needy.

During Ramadan, Muslims are also expected to put more effort into following the teachings of Islam by refraining from violence, anger, envy, greed, lust, profane language, gossip and to try to get along with fellow Muslims better. In addition, all obscene and irreligious sights and sounds are to be avoided.

Fasting during Ramadan is obligatory, but it is forbidden for several groups for whom it would be very dangerous and excessively problematic. These include pre-pubescent children, those with a medical condition such as diabetes, elderly people, and pregnant or breastfeeding women. Other individuals for whom it is considered acceptable not to fast are those who are ill or traveling. Missing fasts usually must be made up for soon afterward, although the exact requirements vary according to circumstance.

Fasting other than Ramadan can be called as ‘nafli fasting’ for which one can get extra reward.

4. Zakāt

The word zakat is originated from ***“zaka”*** which means **“to purify”**. The purpose of zakat is to purify one’s wealth. Zakat or alms-giving is the practice of charitable giving by Muslims based on accumulated wealth, and is obligatory for all who are able to do so. It is considered to be a personal responsibility for Muslims to ease economic hardship for others and eliminate inequality.

Zakat consists of spending 2.5% of one's wealth for the benefit of the poor or needy, including slaves, debtors and travelers. A Muslim may also donate more as an act of voluntary charity (sadaqah), to achieve additional divine reward. Zakat on wealth covers money made in business, savings, income, and so on. In current usage Zakat is treated as a 2.5% collection on most valuables and savings held for a full lunar year, as long as the total value is more than a basic minimum known as nisab.

5. Hajj

This act of worship which must be done once in a lifetime if

1. You have wealth to do so
2. You have health to do so

Once the conditions met, then one should not delay this act of worship. The Hajj is a pilgrimage that occurs during the Islamic month of Dhu al-Hijjah to the holy city of Makkah, and derives from an ancient Arab practice. Every able-bodied Muslim is obliged to make the pilgrimage to Makkah at least once in their lifetime if he or she can afford it. When the pilgrim is around 10 km (6.2 mi) from Makkah, he must dress in Ihram clothing, which consists of two white sheets. Both men and women are required to make the pilgrimage to Makkah. The main rituals of the Hajj include walking seven times around the Kaaba, touching the Black Stone, traveling seven times between Mount Safa and Mount Marwaha, and symbolically stoning the Devil in Mina.

The pilgrim, or the haji, is honored in their community. Hajj should be an expression of devotion to God, not a mean to gain social standing. The believer should be self-aware and examine their intentions in performing the pilgrimage. This should lead to constant striving for self-improvement. A pilgrimage made at any time other than the Hajj season is called an Umrah, and while not mandatory is strongly recommended.

Six Articles of Faith

In Islam, Muslim doctrine is often summarized in "Six Articles of Faith." These are the fundamental beliefs which every Muslim must ascribe to.

1. **One God (Allah)**

The central belief in Islam, and arguably the most important theme of Islam, is that there is one God. A Muslim can't do shirk, it is considered a great crime (Zulm-e-Azeem). We know from the ayah of the Quran that Allah (SWT) can forgive any sin, but cannot forgive the person who associates partners with Allah (SWT) because of it the direct negation of Kalima.

2. **Belief in Angels**

Belief in angels is fundamental to the faith of Islam. According to the Quran, angels do not possess free will, and therefore worship and obey God in total obedience. Angels' duties include communicating revelations from God, glorifying God, recording every person's actions, and taking a person's soul at the time of death. They are made of light and they are numerous in number.

According to the correct opinion, there are 4 angels with every human being all the time. Two angels are at left & right, writing our bad and virtuous deeds and two at the front and back, protecting ourselves. As per Hazrat Ali bin Abi Talib (RA) that when a person has to meet his death, these angels move away.

3. **Prophets (AS)**

Muslims identify the Prophets (AS) of Islam as those humans chosen by Allah (SWT) to be Allah's Messengers.

Allah (SWT) says that we have sent upon every nation, a Rasool, who said Worship one Allah and don't worship false Gods.

They believe that Prophets (AS) are human and not divine, though some are able to perform miracles to prove their claim. Islam teaches that all of Allah's (SWT) Messengers preached the message of Islam; i.e. submission to the will of Allah (SWT).

The Quran mentions Prophet Adam (AS), Prophet Noah (Nuh) (AS), Prophet Abraham (Ibrahim) (AS), Prophet Moses (Musa) (AS) and Prophet Jesus (Isa) (AS) among others, as being Prophets (AS) of Islam. Muslims believe that God finally sent Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) as the last Prophet (Seal of the Prophets) to convey the final summation of all divine revelations to the whole of humanity. This final revelation is believed to be contained in the Quran as well as being exemplified in the life, words, actions and personal characteristics of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) called the Sunnah ("the trodden path"). The collections of sayings and actions of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) are known as the Hadith.

4. Revelations

Muslims believe that God dictated His revelations to the various Prophets. Islam teaches that parts of the previously revealed scriptures, the Tawrat (Torah of Moses), the Zabur (Psalms of David) and the Injil (Gospel of Jesus), had become distorted, either in interpretation and/or in content.

The Quran is viewed by Muslims as the final revelation and literal word of God. For Muslims, all earlier revelations through Adam (AS), Moses (Musa (AS)), David (Dawud (AS)), Jesus (Isa (AS)) and others are clearly and unambiguously restated in the Quran, it, for them, being the fulfillment of all Divine revelation. Muslims believe that the Quran was revealed to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) by Allah (SWT) through the angel Gabriel (Jibrīl (AS)) on many occasions. Muslims usually regard only the original scripture, revealed in Arabic, as being the true Quran. Translations of the Quran into English or any other languages are regarded as being deficient and are referred to as being mere commentaries on the Quran.

5. Resurrection and Judgment

Muslims believe in the "Day of Resurrection" and the Quran emphasizes the resurrection of the body, which is a distinct break with the pre-Islamic Arabian understanding of death. Muslims believe that on 'The Day of Resurrection' all humankind will be judged according to their good and bad deeds.

The Quran describes this as,

"Whoever does an atom's weight of good, will see it; and whoever does an atom's weight of evil, will see it" [Surah Al-Zalzalah: 7-8]

The Quran mentions certain sins that are punishable by hell, such as disbelief in God and dishonesty. However, the Quran also teaches that God will forgive the sins of those who

sincerely repent and that one's good deeds, such as charity, prayer and compassion will be rewarded with entry to heaven.

6. Qadr (Divine Decree)

Muslims believe that Allah (SWT) has full knowledge and control over all that occurs. Everything in the world that occurs, good or bad, has been pre-ordained and nothing can happen unless permitted by Allah (SWT). According to Muslim theologians, although events are pre-ordained, humans possess free will in that each of us has the faculty to choose between right and wrong, and so each of us is responsible for her/his own actions.

Concept of Leadership in Islam

Leadership can be learned, practiced and adopted by an individual. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, “Each one of you is a shepherd on his flock”.

Different Definitions of Leadership

Leadership is difficult to define in a single definition. However, we can say that it is the quality to do acts of goodness and then people join you and you lead them.

“Leadership is like beauty. It’s hard to define, but you know it when you see it”. Warren Bennis

Leadership is

1. The pursuit of bettering your environment
2. Knowing your team and yourself well
3. Giving people the tools to succeed
4. Open, authentic and positive influence
5. Clarity, confidence, and courage
6. Building consensus and common goals
7. Being the solution to problems
8. Helping others achieve the impossible
9. To develop next-generation leaders
10. Building followers

Leadership is the ability to help people achieve things they don't think are possible.

Leader

Leaders are coaches with a passion for developing people, not the players; they get satisfaction from achieving the objects through others.

As a leader, one must know which of his team members are to be used where? It’s a part of being a good leader because you understand which person should be used in which capacity. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) did this in his life, he took the advice of Hazrat Suleman Farsi (RA) of digging the trench for a battle as he was an expert of that area. He made Hazrat Khalid bin Waleed (RA), one of the generals as He (PBUH) knew that Hazrat Khalid bin Waleed (RA) was a master of the battlefield. So, Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) put each person in the right place. He did what a leader does, irrespective of considering his blood relations for higher ranks. Each one of them was given the task on merit. A leader recognizes the strengths of his team members.

The imam of a masjid is a very good example of a leader:

- Follow him in Salah
- Don't overtake him
- If he makes a mistake, inform him
- If he doesn't listen, you're not to blame
- Imam has to be the best from you (most knowledge of the Qur'an & Sunnah)

Imam must be the best and knowledgeable person as per general rule so that people can consult him in case of any confusion or query.

Mashwara – Seeking Advice

It is recommended in Islam to seek advice from all. The Even Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) seeks advice from his companions.

The decisions can be taken in three different ways.

1. **Democratic:** The majority opinion
2. **Consultative:** Ask those who know best or most qualified
3. **Authoritative:** Take a decision yourself

All these methods are fine depending upon the situation. So as a leader can use all these options can depend upon the situation.

- **Pray Istikhara** – For this we pray 2 nafal and then recite the dua of Istekhara in which we ask Allah (SWT) that "O Allah, if this decision is good for me then make it easy for me, but if it's bad for me in this world and akhirah then move me away from it and give peace to my heart that I am able to take that decision".

- Then take the decision without waiting for any sign.
- If there is a hindrance, you can change course
- Once the decision has been made, adhere to it
- Don't say "I told you so"
- Obey the ameer unless he/she goes against the Shariah

Once you make the decision, then put your trust in Allah (SWT), and even if something happens which is not in our favor even then there must be some Khair (betterment) for us in it.

There is no "I" in the team

Leaders focus on their teams, not on themselves. They think of themselves as a part of the team so there is no "I" in the team. They referred every victory to the common effort of their team.

5 Reasons Why Leaders are Followed

These are the levels of the relationship of leadership with their subordinates.

1. Leader commands the top position
2. Leader has a relationship with the subordinates regardless of status
3. Employee wants to be part of the leader's team as they produce results
4. Employee wants to grow as an individual and learn new skills
5. Employee respects the leader's judgment and personality

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) did the same. He (PBUH) first made his space in the people of Arab, won their trust that they did the honor of fixing Hajr-e-Aswad even when he didn't announce him as a Prophet.

He was famous for his honesty and truthfulness so when he invited people towards Allah (SWT), some people accepted him who have purity in their hearts.

(Yusuf) said, "Appoint me over the storehouses of the land. Indeed, I will be a knowing guardian." [Surah Yusuf: 55]

Hazrat Yusuf (AS), asked the king of Egypt that I am trustworthy and knowledgeable in this area so appoint me for this job of finance minister. Also, Allah (SWT) has bestowed Hazrat Yusuf (AS) with the knowledge of interpreting dreams so it was his plus point. So, he interpreted the dream of the king of Egypt and told him that you will have seven years of prosperity and then seven years of hardship. As he was sure of his knowledge so he asked to be appointed to this position and other people may not be able to perform this task as he would have performed.

Leader is also accountable for their deeds as leaders.

"And keep yourself patient (by being) with those who call upon their Lord in the morning and the evening, seeking His face. And let not your eyes pass beyond them, desiring adornments of the worldly life, and do not obey one whose heart We have made heedless of Our remembrance and who follows his desire and whose affair is ever (in) neglect." [Surah Al-Kahf: 28]

A leader, a friend and any relationship should only be made with those who fear and worship Allah (SWT).

"Do not extend your eyes toward that by which We have given enjoyment to [certain] categories of the disbelievers, and do not grieve over them. And lower your wing to the believers". [Surah Hijr: 88]

Allah (SWT) said to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) that you serve them (believers). Leadership concept in Islam is completely different. In Islam, a leader serves the people and people get benefits from him.

At the battle of Uhud, archers did not obey Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) but he did not turn his back on them.

"So, by mercy from Allah, [O Mohammad], you were lenient with them. And if you had been rude [in speech] and harsh in heart, they would have disbanded from about you. So, pardon them and ask forgiveness for them and consult them in the matter. And when you have decided, then rely upon Allah. Indeed, Allah loves those who rely [upon Him]". [Surah Al-Imran: 159]

Although Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) was getting revelations from Allah (SWT), he did not need anyone's advice on any decision, but he always took advice from his companions which show that taking advice is an important aspect of a leader and makes team bonding.

Islamic Caliphate

Caliph or Khalifah

A Khalifah (Caliph) was meant to be the successor of the Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), whose job was to provide Muslims with the most desired leadership, according to the commandments of Allah (SWT) and His Messenger Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). He was not supposed to rule the believers, but only to act as a guiding principle in matters concerning the implementation of Islamic rules and regulations leading towards a just and peaceful society.

1. Hazrat Abu Bakr Siddique (R.A) (June 8, 632-August 23, 634 A.D)

He was born in 573 A.D, is almost 2 years younger than the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) belonged to a noble family of Bunu Tamim of Qureyshi tribe in Makkah. His original name was Abdullah ibn Abu Quhafa. He started doing the trade as a profession and accompanied Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) on some business missions. He was the closest companion of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and shared great personality characteristics of truthfulness, honesty, and integrity with Him.

He as the First Caliph

With the passing, away of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), the Muslim community was faced with the problem of succession. Who would be its leader? There were four persons obviously marked for leadership: Hazrat Abu Bakr al-Siddique (R.A), who had accompanied Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) to Madinah ten years before and had been proved very generous in the need of hours for Islam. Hazrat Umar Ibn al-Khattab (RA), an able and trusted Companion of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH); 'Hazrat Usman Ibn 'Affan (R.A), a respected early convert; and 'Hazrat Ali ibn Abi Talib (R.A), Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s cousin and son-in-law and a very pious and knowledgeable personality.

To avoid contention among various groups, 'Hazrat Umar (R.A) suddenly grasped the Hazrat Abu Bakr's (R.A) hand, the traditional sign of recognition of a new leader. Soon everyone concurred and before dusk Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) had been recognized as the Khalifah.

In his first address as caliph, he said,

"I have been given the authority over you, and I am not the best of you. If I do well, help me; and if I do wrong, set me right. Sincere regard for truth is loyalty and disregard for truth is treachery. The weak amongst you shall be strong with me until I have secured his rights if God wills, and the strong amongst you shall be weak with me until I have wrested from him the rights of others if God wills. Obey me so long as I obey God and His Messenger. But if I disobey

God and His Messenger, you owe me no obedience. Arise for your prayer, God has mercy upon you".

His Accomplishments as Caliph

Hazrat Abu Bakr's (R.A) caliphate was short but important. An exemplary leader, he lived simply, assiduously fulfilled his religious obligations, and was accessible and sympathetic to his people. But he also stood firm when, in the wake of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)'s death, some tribes renounced Islam; in what was a major accomplishment, Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) swiftly disciplined them. He also defeated the rebellion of several Arab tribes (the Ridda Wars, or the Wars of Apostasy).

The Ridda or Apostasy Wars were a series of conflicts with various Arab tribes that had become Muslim in the last years of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) life. These people thought that their agreement to become a Muslim was a contract only with Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and that once Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) was dead, the contract was no longer valid. But Muslim's thought has always been that becoming a Muslim is a lifetime commitment and, should a person's belief waver, it is the responsibility of the community to help the person back to a state of belief.

Later, he consolidated the support of the tribes within the Arabian Peninsula and subsequently funneled their energies against the powerful empires of the East: the Sassanians in Persia and the Byzantines in Syria, Palestine, and Egypt.

In short, he demonstrated the viability of the Muslim state. Some other major contributions of his were to assemble the scattering Muslims to common Islamic faith and the compilation of the Holy Quran in hard copy for the first time.

His Death

The time of his Caliphate was very short, i.e. 27 months only. Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) died on Monday, 23rd August, 634 A.D and is buried next to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

2. Hazrat Umar Farooq (R.A) (August 23, 634-November 7, 644 A.D)

He was born in 580 A.D, is almost 10 years younger than the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Hazrat Umar ibn Khattab (R.A) belonged to the Adi family of the Qureyshi tribe of Makkah. He used to graze cattle in his early age and was also among a few educated people of Makkah at that time. In his youth, He was physically strong and was proven as a wrestler. He accepted Islam when he was actually going to kill (God forbid) Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) but after listening to the recitation of Quranic Verses in the house of his sister, he acknowledged the Ayahs (verses) as true and embraced Islam at the hands of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

He as the Second Caliph

In 634, Hazrat Umar Ibn al-Khattab (R.A) became the second caliph. He had been one of the chief advisors to Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) and had served as his secretary. Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) named Hazrat Umar Ibn al-Khattab (R.A) as his successor because of his willpower, intelligence, political astuteness, impartiality, justice, and care for poor and underprivileged people.

His Accomplishments as Caliph

During his Khilafat, the Islamic dominion reached the far-off corners of the world, including Roman and Persian regions. Hazrat Umar (R.A) extended Islam's temporal rule over Syria, Egypt, Iraq, and Persia in what from a purely military standpoint were astonishing victories. Within four years after the death of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) the Muslim state had extended its sway over all of Syria and had, at a famous battle fought during a sandstorm near the River Yarmuk, blunted the power of the Byzantines – whose ruler Heraclius had shortly before disdainfully rejected the letter from the unknown Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) of Arabia.

Being the Second Caliph of Islam, the major contributions of caliph Hazrat Umar (R.A) include implementation of peace and justice in Muslim society, the formation of Baitul Maal for maintenance and provision of finances, the division of larger regions into smaller provinces, making of present Hijri (Islamic) Calendar etc.

His caliphate was a high point in early Islamic history. He was noted for his justice, social ideals, administration, and statesmanship. His innovations left all enduring imprint on social welfare, taxation, and the financial and administrative fabric of the growing empire.

His Death

Hazrat Umar (R.A) was assassinated by a rebel while he was praying congregational Salah in the mosque. He died three days after that unfortunate happening, i.e. on 7th November, 644 A.D. Upon his wish, Hazrat Ayesha (R.A) gave the permission to bury Hazrat Umar (R.A) alongside Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

3. Hazrat Usman Ghani (R.A) (November 11, 644-July 17, 656 A.D)

He was born in 573 A.D, is almost 2 years younger than the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Hazrat Usman ibn Affan (R.A) belonged to the Umayyah family of the Qureyshi tribe of Makkah.He readily accepted Islam when his close friend Hazrat Abu Bakr (R.A) told him about it. He was a wealthy man and he spent most of it in the true service of Islam like buying a well from Jew in Madinah and making it free for use for all Muslims and acquiring a portion of land to enlarge the capacity of Masjid-e-Nabawi. Due to his generosity, he was commonly known as Al-Ghani.

He as the Third Caliph

After the death of Caliph Hazrat Umar (R.A), an advisory council composed of the Companions of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) selected Hazrat Usman (R.A) as the third caliph.

His Accomplishments as Caliph

Hazrat Usman (R.A) achieved much during his reign. He pushed forward with the pacification of Persia, continued to defend the Muslim state against the Byzantines, added what is now Libya to the empire, and subjugated most of Armenia. Hazrat Usman (R.A) also, established an Arab navy, which fought a series of important engagements with the Byzantines.

During his time, he contributed by capturing the far-off regions of the world like North Africa, the formation of first Muslim Naval Force and beating the Roman realm. He also gathered Muslims on single Tajweed of Quran by making its common recital process.

His Death

These successes, however, were qualified by serious administrative weaknesses. Hazrat Usman (R.A) was accused of favoritism to members of his family – the clan of Umayyah. Negotiations over such grievances were opened by representatives from Egypt, but soon collapsed and Hazrat Usman (R.A) was killed on 17th of July, 656 A.D. He died at the old age of 84 and is buried in Jannat-ul-Baqi (graveyard in Madinah).

4. Hazrat Ali Murtaza (R.A) (656-661 A.D)

He was born in 600 A.D, being the First Cousin of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and almost 30 years younger than Him (PBUH). Hazrat Ali ibn Abi Talib (R.A) belonged to a highly-respected family of Bani Hashim of Qureyshi tribe in Makkah. He was the first one among young ones and one the earliest of all the acceptors of Islam. He also risked his life for the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) by lying on His (PBUH) bed at night when non-believers had already planned to kill (God forbid) Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), successfully returned the entrusted possessions to their original owners the very next day and migrated to Madinah. Hazrat Ali (R.A) had the great honor of having married the youngest and the most beloved Daughter of Hazrat Mohammad (PBUH) Hazrat Fatima (R.A) and being the Father of Hazrat Imam Hassan (R.A) and Hazrat Imam Hussain (R.A), who made the greatest sacrifice later for the purpose of upholding Islam. He fought every battle with huge courage right from the very first clash with infidels, i.e. Ghazwa Badr. At the occasion of Ghazwa-e-Khaibar, considered to be the toughest of all battles that the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) fought, Hazrat Ali (R.A).

No doubt, Ali is from Me (PBUH) and I am from Ali , and Ali will be the Saint of every Momin after Me, and will keep a love from him (Momin), no one will be hatred from Him. (Tirmidhi)

He as the Fourth Caliph

Following the assassination of Caliph Hazrat Usman (R.A), Hazrat Ali (R.A) was literally forced to accept the position of the Caliph. He did so reluctantly on the condition that He would rule strictly by the true Sunnah of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and by the ordinances contained in the Qur'an. However, He assumed leadership at a time when the Islamic world was not unified. He was unwilling to compromise His principles for the sake of political expediency.

His Accomplishments as Caliph

Being the fourth Khalifah of Islam, Hazrat Ali ul Murtaza (R.A) tried his best to unite Muslims and make peace, but the resistance from hypocrites had become very strong. He fought them and destroyed most of the Kharijites (rebellion movement) in the battle of Nahrawan and introduce the reforms in taxes.

He removed the corrupt regional governors of the Islamic empire, and demanded honesty, integrity, accountability, and compassion from the government officials. He himself adopted an extremely austere lifestyle.

His Death

When he was 63 years of age, Hazrat Ali (R.A) was martyred with a poisoned sword by one of the rebels while he was performing the prostration of Fajar Salah in Kufa mosque on the 19th of Ramadan, 40 A.H. (661 A.D.).

Umayyads and Abbasids

Introduction

The discussion under the perspective of leadership is continued, we would like to discuss what happened after the Rashidun Caliphate. We would see some interesting points to talk about Umayyad and Abbasids. We have talked about some of the great qualities of a good leader and what it takes to be a good leader. Here, we have excellent examples to compare and contrast of Right Caliphs and the successors of the Umayyad and Abbasids. Also, some factors regarding the rising empire of Muslims and its decline.

Umayyad Period

During the time of rightly Caliphs, the Islamic empire expanded and it was known as *Dar-ul-Islam* where Islamic principles and provisions were followed. The Caliph was supposed to follow strictly the Qur'an and Sunnah, which were primary sources of the Caliphate. In this Caliphate, *Ahlul Kitaab* were not forced to embrace Islam, but they were allowed to follow their own religious practices representing religious tolerance as long as they pay *Jizya*, that is, for their protection under attacks or battles. Although, Muslims were also to pay a tax known as zakat.

Expansion of Umayyads

The expansion under Umayyads can be observed from Spain, Persia, some parts of Pakistan, Mesopotamia, North Africa, Crete, Sicily, Sardinia, Northwest India, and Eastern Mediterranean Sea.

The capital of the Umayyads was at Damascus. The Umayyads not only brought wealth, but also new converts to Islam. However, the domestic turmoil remained prevailing and later turned severe within the empire. The riches of the world were reaching in their hands.

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) mentioned that, "I do not fear for your poverty, but the wealth of the world opens for you which will be the cause of the Fitna." ***(Sahih Hadith).***

Umayyads became wealthy and they moved away from Taqwa and lived lavish lifestyles like royals. They did not care about the principles of Islam and Sunnah.

The only notable and devout leaders among Umayyads is the Hazrat Umer bin Abdul Aziz also known as Umer II. He was also known as a just, upright and an honest leader. His era can be regarded as the golden period of the Umayyad. He lifted away from the Jizya tax on those Non-believers who convert to Islam. He lifted away all extra allowances to his own family members. He treated everyone equally without any nepotism. The relatives of the leader were not given any privileges as they were treated as a common man in the society. He was later poisoned when his successive government tried to reverse his financial and tax policies

Decline of Umayyads

The Umayyad became soft and corrupt due to wealth. Warrior lifestyle was abandoned as was in the Caliphate. The arts, crafts, entertainment, music and decadent lifestyle was prevailing among Umayyads. The difference between a rich and a poor has clearly been seen in Umayyads. Along the Indian frontier, warrior settlers revolted against the Umayyads with the help of the Abbasids.

In 750 CE, the Abbasids replaced Umayyads, and Umayyads were completely wiped out. The grandson of Umayyads escaped in Spain and established an exiled caliphate in Cordoba in Spain. There is nothing spectacular Umayyads to mention here in terms of any massive achievements apart from the expansion of the empire.

Advent of Abbasids

In 750 CE, the Umayyads were completely wiped out by the Abbasids. The Muslim empire expansion was gaining strength. Abbasids have to tackle the internal conflicts. The period between 786 CE to 861 CE was known as the golden era of the Abbasids. The empire reached great cultural heights. In the era 813 CE to 833 CE, Mamoon was in power, he put down many rebellions and had fought wars with the Byzantine empire.

Abbasids empire lasted from 750 CE to 1258 CE.By the invasion of the Mongols under the leadership of Changez Khan, the Abbasids came to an end. Strange to say, the invading Mongols accepted Islam fascinated by Muslims 'architecture. The Abbasids followed the decadent and luxurious lifestyle, they considered themselves above the principles of Islam. Abbasids built a strong bureaucratic government to rule their empire. Muslim merchants expanded their trades across Africa, the Indian Ocean, and the Mediterranean Sea.

Characteristics of Abbasids

Abbasids built a centralized state with Baghdad as Capital. The absolute power was at the center of the state. The bureaucracy was under wazirs. There was a royal executioner. The revenue in the form of taxes and tribute was collected. The Abbasids were less powerful at a distance and strong at the center and they were not as sophisticated as the Umayyads were. The Abbasids caliphs placed themselves above the Islamic law. They remained remote from the people and instead they were more involved in their decadent lifestyle. There are golden achievements worth mentioning in terms of Science, Mathematics, Medicine, and Architecture etc.

Some of important Khaleefa Haroon-ur-Rasheed, Khaleefa Mamoon-ur-Rasheed and Al-Mansoor. During their time, they built Bait-ul-Hikma (House of Wisdom), which refers to a public academy and a center of excellence for knowledge. Muslims were very much into these houses of wisdom and they made many discoveries. The House of Wisdom was a formal academy. A lot of knowledgeable stuff could be found in this library, but it was destroyed by Mongols. Advancements in education, degree-granting university, advancements in law, Islamic jurisprudence, matters of Fiqh, Asool-al-Fiqh, in theology Imam Ahmad ibn-e-Hanbil who connected people to the Book of Allah (SWT) and the Sunnah. Many of them were

polymaths, Ibn-e-Seena an authority in Philosophy and expert in modern medicine and had written a canon of medicine. Ibn-e-Seena and Ibn-e-Rushd were two authoritative figures in Philosophy. Al-Khawrizmi- famous Mathematician and invented Algebra, Trigonometry, the science of Algorithms and scientific methods. Al-bairuni- famous Physicist and Astronomer. Al-kindi- famous Chemist. In social science, Ibne Khuldoon- a great historian and human behaviorist- his volumes of works on these topics can be found out.

According to Ashfaq Ahmed: 'Degrees are mere the receipt for your educational expenditure, but the true knowledge is seen through your good conduct.' The character is the most important aspect considered in Islam if you lose your character, you lose your leadership and in the sight of Allah (SWT).

The purpose of education is also to make your character best if education is not making you more upright than your education system is not right. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, 'I have been sent to perfect the good character.'

Allah (SWT) mentioned that He (PBUH) has the best of the character. In Qur'an said,

"And We have not sent you, [O Muhammad], except as a mercy to the worlds".
[Al-Anbya: 107]

Muslims were first who created the first maps. Those were very detailed and ancient maps. Muslims discovered coffee to awake for tahajjud and soap for their cleanliness.

Europeans Influenced by Muslims Knowledge

Europeans visited and learned the Arabic language to learn knowledge. They came out of the dark ages, they learned and took books with them. In Europe, people opposed religion due to the orthodoxically and influential nature of the powerful church. Because Europe believed that the religious thoughts were resisting them from advancements and therefore they opposed church and gone through the enlightened era of empirical knowledge. As Muslims, we accept the empirical knowledge, but our primary source of knowledge is divine knowledge. Christian went through downfall and they came out to be more knowledgeable about the advent of secular ideology. People of this era, like Carl Marks, Sigmund Freud, etc., where atheist and anti-religion. Therefore, those who had written books regarding the backwardness of religion. They all were well-versed of only Christianity not of Islam. Whereas, Islam is a more modern religion and accepts modern knowledge.

Decline of the Abbasids

Due to the royal and lavish lifestyle, Abbasid faced their downfall. Their decadent lifestyle and considering them above Islamic law made them vulnerable. When Mongols attacked them, there was no one who would go to perform Hajj. People were busy in their lavish lifestyle. People who do not learn from history, history makes them lessons for the others. Abbasids left the Quran and Sunnah and they died out completely in the history.

Knowing Islam

Quran is the word of Allah (SWT) and Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) is the last messenger of Allah (SWT). Then now a question arises that what is the purpose of our life? Allah (SWT) mentioned in the Quran,

"And I did not create the jinn and mankind except to worship Me".
[Surah Adh-Dhariyat: 56]

Humans in one way or another are the slave to something; either we are the slave to our Nafs or we are the slave to Allah (SWT) but the real liberation comes through slavery. Allah (SWT) has provided a code of conduct for the humans to lead their life. If the person will not follow the code of conduct, he/she will become the slave of his/her own Nafs. For example, a person addicted to alcohol, addicted to haram relationships or addicted to drugs thinks that he/she is free but instead they are now slaves of their own Nafs. Even realizing that they are on the wrong path they are not able to quit that slavery. On the other hand, when a person enslaves himself to Allah (SWT) his life becomes smoother and Allah (SWT) has promised the person to give him ***Hayat-e-Taiyaba*** – a good life. A question that is always asked is about that Allah (SWT) has said in Quran that,

"There is no compulsion in religion". [Surah Al-Baqarah: 255]

What does it mean? Whether everything in the deen (religion) is optional or not? The answer to the question is that this ayah refers to the fact that we cannot force any person to accept Islam. We can give him Dawah towards Islam, but cannot force him. But once a person accepts Islam, then there is a compulsion, he should follow the code of conduct defined by Allah (SWT) in deen (religion). For example, if you want to join some school or a college the joining is in the person's own will but after joining it is the compulsion to follow the code of conduct of that school or college. If any student acts or behaves against the rules and regulations of that school or college, he will be held accountable by the authorities. This is the reason that the authority given to anybody is a responsibility and that person will be accountable for it. E.g. In a house, a father is head of the house. He is responsible for the laws to be followed in home.

Perspectives of Knowing Islam

1. *The Sources of Islamic Knowledge*
2. *Importance of Tauheed*
3. *Acceptance of Deeds*
4. *The Saved Sect*

The Sources of Islamic Knowledge

There are two basic sources of Islamic knowledge

1. The Nobel Quran
2. Sunnah of Messenger (PBUH)

1. The Nobel Quran

The basic source of knowledge in Islam is the Quran and till the Day of Judgement there will be no change in the Quran for any Muslim.

The second source of knowledge is the Sunnah or Hadith of Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Both sources must be interpreted primarily in the light of the earliest generation as they have first-hand knowledge from the source i.e. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) himself. For example, the companion of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), Hazrat Abdullah ibn-e-Masud (R.A) and Hazrat Abdullah ibn Abbas (R.A) narrated that they have knowledge of about 80 Surahs of Quran that in which context they are revealed. So, while interpreting the Quran and hadith, it is very important to refer to these companions of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

It is very important to take verses of the Quran in the right context. For example, Allah (SWT) mentioned in Surah Tauba and Surah Anfal that **"*Kill them where you find them*"** referring to the Non-Muslims. If any layman will interpret this ayah without having the background knowledge, it can cause much damage, but when we refer this ayah considering the context in which it is revealed we came to know that it specifically refers to the battlefield not in general. Otherwise, the killing of one innocent human being means that you kill the whole humanity. Similarly, saving the life of one human means saving the whole humanity.

The verses of Holy Quran and Hadith of Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) should match on a common subject to having the clear picture that what Allah (SWT) wanted to teach us. Often times people take the specific verses from Holy Quran and make them general and vice versa. Either way, they will go wrong. That is why we have scholars that have knowledge of religion and we can refer to them for evidence. In Surah Al-Maida, the fifth Surah of Holy Quran, Allah (SWT) mentions in verses.

"And whosoever does not judge by what Allah has revealed, such are the <u>Kafirun</u>."
[Surah Al-Maida 5: 44]

And whosoever does not judge by that which Allah has revealed, such are the <u>Zalimun</u>."
[Surah Al-Maida 5: 45]

"And whosoever does not judge by what Allah has revealed (then) such (people) are the <u>Fasiqun</u>." [Surah Al-Maida 5: 47]

"And so, judge among them by what Allah has revealed and <u>follow not their vain desires</u>." [Surah Al-Maida 5: 49]

Which means that we should judge and live according to the book of Allah (SWT) otherwise we will be considered as *Kafirun, Zalimun,* and *Fasiqun.*

We make judgements on what we see. There are exceptions too; for example, Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) offered absentee funeral prayer (ghaibana Namaz-e-Janaza) for Najashi – the king of Abbasynia. Apparently, he died as a disbeliever, but when Ashab's of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) inquired, the Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) mentions that he died upon Islam. He did not confess it due to social pressures from his tribe or fear of death.

Allah (SWT) mentioned that one who is not judging by the book of Allah (SWT) is a disbeliever, but this does not take any person from major folds of Islam. He will be considered as a sinner. On the other hand, if the person is involved in black magic he/she will out from the circle of Islam. It is one of the major sins that will nullify him/her from being Muslim. Shirk is also one of the sins which nullify us from Islam.

2. Sunnah of Messenger (PBUH)

Allah (SWT) mentions in the Holy Quran,

"Allah has sent down to you the Book (The Qur'an), and al-Hikmah, and taught you that which you knew not." [Surah An-Nisa: 113]

Imam Shafi' mentions that it is the unanimous consensus of Ulema that Hikmah refers the Sunnah of Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Quran and Sunnah are both parts of the revelation. The Quran is in the form of the book while the Sunnah in the form of actions of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Allah (SWT) mention in Surah Al – Najam that "Whatever he (Prophet Mohammad (PBUH)) says – it is but a revelation". Allah mentions about prayers in Holy Quran, but not once how-to prayer. It is not mentioned that we have to pray 2 Faraz rakat for Fajr or 4 for Zuhr, we find this from the Sunnah of Holy Prophet (PBUH) and this was also a part of revelation.

If a person mentions that he/she is following Quran, but not Sunnah, then he/she is missing one important part of revelation. That is why Allah (SWT) is mentioned in the Holy Quran that,

And whatever the Messenger gives you, take it, and whatever he forbids you, leave it. And fear Allah: truly Allah is severe in punishment." [Surah Al-Hashr: 7]

"It is <u>not fitting</u> for a Believer, man or woman, when a matter has been <u>decided by Allah and His Messenger</u> to have any option about their decision…" [Surah Al-Ahzab: 36]

"Whoever <u>obeys the Messenger</u>, he indeed obeys Allah." [Surah An-Nisa: 80]

All the above-mentioned references throw light on the importance of the Sunnah of Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). According to Ahle–Sunnat School of thought, the most authentic books of Ahadith are Shahih Muslim and Sahih Bukhari. The criteria for selection of Ahadith were very strict by these scholars. It is narrated that Imam Bukhari collected more than 1.5 lac Ahadith but he took only 7000 to put into Sahih – the most authentic. There were other Ahadith too, that are known to be fabricated or whose narrators cannot be verified. Those Ahadith are also mentioned in other Ahadith books to give people awareness.

As Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) mentioned that "Whosoever attributes to me something that I have not said, then, let him reserve his seat in hellfire".

Sahih Bukhari and Muslim have known to have only Sahih Ahadith in them. The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "The best of the people is my generation, then, those after them, then those after them..." *[Bukhari / Muslim / Abu Dawood / Tirmidhi /An -Nasai]*. Also, Allah (SWT) is mentioned in the Holy Quran,

"And the foremost to embrace Islam of the Muhajirun and the Ansar (i.e. the Companions) and also those who followed them exactly (in Faith). Allah (SWT) is well-pleased with them as they are well-pleased with Him. He (SWT) has prepared for them Gardens under which rivers flow (Paradise), to dwell therein forever. That is the supreme success."
[Surah At-Taubah: 100]

Righteous Deeds

"Righteous deeds" are one of the key concepts of the Qur'an. In Arabic, the word "righteousness" comprises the meanings of good, beneficial and right. In Arabic, the verb "to amend"(Islah) is also derived from the same root. Consequently, in English, every type of beneficial work or action is done for the good of religion is expressed by the word "righteous deed."

Mandatory rules are called “Farz or Wajibat” while recommended actions are called “Nawafil or Mustahibat” which are also called righteous deeds.

Allah (SWT) is the supreme authority. He planned everybody’s life, furnish with all necessities before his birth. This is the concept of Qadar or predestination. The story of Prophet Hazrat Musa (AS) and Hazrat Khizer (AS) indicates that Allah (SWT) has complete knowledge while man’s knowledge is limited. At times, we think that things are not in our favor, but we don’t know that we might have been presented with the best possible solution.

“Know you not that Allah knows all that is in the heaven and on the earth? Verily, it is (all) in the Book (Al Lawh Al Mahfooz). Verily, that is easy for Allah”. [Surah Al-Hajj: 70]

At another place,

"It is possible that you dislike a thing which is good for you, and that you love a thing which is bad for you. But God knows, and you do not know." [Surah Al-Baqarah: 216]

Only God knows if the desired end will have beneficial consequences for man.

Allah’s (SWT) plan is vital for the success in this world and hereafter but it has flexibility. It allows the man to use his free will. He uses his free will according to his knowledge for which he is answerable. When the hardships turn a person towards Allah (SWT) it means this difficulty is a mercy and trial from Allah (SWT). On the other hand, if that difficulty takes a person away from Allah (SWT) then it is punishment, for example, excessive wealth: if a person spends for sake of Allah (SWT) then it is a mercy from Him otherwise it is a punishment that reflects from the story of Eric.

The salvation of an individual is not attained only through faith; the signs of sincere faith, righteous deeds, also save the soul. Saying "I believe" yet failing to comply with the commandments of religion does not lead a person to salvation. The Quran states this issue in this manner:

“Do men think that they will be left alone on saying, "We believe", and that they will not be tested? We tested those before them, and God will certainly know those who are true from those who are false.” (Surah Al-Ankabut: 2-3)

Allah (SWT) looks at the profile of His man and when he wants to raise the status of His man, He sends trials and hardships towards his way, so that he deals those trials with patience thus gets the higher status in Firdous ul Ala'a (the place with prophets in paradise).

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) says that, "the Prophets of Allah (SWT) are the most tested people in respect of their patience and I am the most tested amongst them".

He has buried 5 of his children, face the hardships after the announcement of Prophethood and losing his loved ones are some of his tests.

Allah Says in Quran who restrain their anger and do sabr (patience) for the sake of Allah (SWT), Allah raises their status.

"Who spend [in the cause of Allah] during ease and hardship and who restrain anger and who pardon the people - and Allah loves the doers of good". [Ale Imran: 134]

Ranks of Pious People

There is a division of ranks of pious people.

1. Muslim
2. Momin
3. Muttaqqi
4. Mohsin

When a person embraces Islam at that very moment he will be called as **Muslim**. When he does mandatory deeds (as Salah, Saum, Zakah etc.) and other good deeds but still commits sins sometimes is called **Momin**. When the Momin gets Al-Yaqeen (belief) from Allah (SWT) and with performing all good and mandatory deeds he leaves sins then he becomes **Muttaqqi**. When his belief became more and more until it's complete then he becomes **Moshin**. He is a doer of Ehsan (beautiful deeds).

The word Mohsin means " the one who brings perfection in something". Allah says" WALLAHU YUHIBB UL MOHSINEEN" (And Allah loves the Mohsineen). Allah (SWT) mentions one of the qualities of the people of Ehsan that they swallow their anger.

Once a container of hot water was dropped by a maid mistakenly on the head of Hazrat Ali bin Hussain (RA) the grandson of Hazrat Ali bin Abi Talib (RA). She was scared as there were three offenses:

1. The container was bang on the head of her master.
2. The container was broken.
3. The master became wet.

She thought that he will be angry and punish her so she said quickly: "... Those who control (their) anger…" Hazrat Ali bin Hussain (RA) said that he was not angry. Then she recited the next part of the Ayah: "... And are forgiving towards people..." He said he had forgiven her.

Then she finished the verse: "... Allah loves those who do good..." He then told her that she was free.

Islam is a set of beliefs. It is not enough to believe in the concepts given by Islam, but it leads towards actions. A Muslim must make sure that all his actions and activities, whether they are money making, family traditions, tribal identity, national patriotism or following fashion is according to Allah's (SWT) command and to please Him. In addition, he should not do the righteous things outwardly, but his intention behind the deed is important. Doing righteous deeds or being pious to impress people around has no value. We find in the Quran,

Say, [O Muhammad], "Shall we [believers] inform you of the greatest losers as to [their] deeds? [Sura Al-Kahaf: 103]

Allah (SWT), may or may not accept our righteous deeds, but there are some criteria for acceptance and rejection of those deeds.

"And We shall turn to whatever deeds they did, and We shall make such deeds as scattered floating particles of dust." [Al-Furqan: 23]

At another place,

"Those whose efforts have been wasted in this life while they thought that they were acquiring good by their deeds!" [Al-Kahf: 104]

The deeds which we have performed not exclusively for Allah (SWT), may not save us from the fire of Hell at the day of judgement. Such deeds might be thrown in our face, which we have performed to please others than Allah (SWT).

Islam encourages the community life and supports the idea of helping each other. It is very important to maintain peace and a healthy environment in the society. It is also a right deed to keep the unity in ummah and society.

"A believer to another believer is like a building whose different parts support each other." ***[Sahih Al-Bukhari]***

Righteous deeds accumulate the eternal benefits which will mostly be required by the people on the day of judgement. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) always encouraged to carry out the good deeds, no matter how small it is, even a smile to a neighbor or removing the harmful object from the street.

Reported by the beloved wife of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), Hazrat Ayesha (RA) that, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said that, "you should do whatever good deeds you can, for Allah (SWT) does not get tired of giving rewards until you get tired". ***[Sahih Al-Bukhari, Sahih Al-Muslim]***

Conditions for Acceptable Deeds

Introduction

Every deed is not acceptable in the view of Allah (SWT). Allah (SWT) accepts only those deeds which are performed in the state of Emaan (Faith), with Ikhlaas (sincere intentions) and according to Shar'iah (Qur'an and Sunnah). Allah (SWT) mentioned clearly in the Qur'an, its translation is given as,

"And whoever seeks a religion other than Islam, it will never be accepted of him, And in the Hereafter he will be one of the losers." [Al-Imran: 85]

The final and ultimate religion near Allah (SWT) is Islam, Allah (SWT) will not accept anything from those who did not accept Islam. The reward for any action will be according to the intentions, if a person recites Salat for His appreciation from people, he will get nothing from Allah (SWT) in return. Similarly, a Shaheed (martyred) in the name his own fame will also face nothing but the anger of Allah (SWT) and so on.

Deeds in the Name of Allah (Ikhlas)

The deeds done in loneliness and for the sake of Allah (SWT) are the best and the most accepted one near Allah (SWT). Pharisaism is not acceptable in Islam. Allah (SWT) recommends and rewards the acts and deeds performed for Him alone. If a person performs an act with expecting the reward from Allah (SWT) ignoring the voices of others about his work, then he will definitely be rewarded by Him.

Whereas if a person's good deeds are affected by the words of his friends and people around, he will although become famous among them for his acts, but will get nothing as a reward from Allah (SWT). Allah (SWT) says,

"And whosoever does not content with the Messenger (PBUH) after guidance has been made clear to him, and follows the way other than the way of the believers, We shall leave in the path he has chosen, And land him in hell, What an evil destination." [Al-Nisa: 115]

Islam is a complete religion, one does not need to add something into it or subtract from it. To add into this argument, let's see an example of a person who with full attention to Allah (SWT) wants to perform prostration three times in every Rakat of Fajar payer instead of two tomes, or he wants to pray three Rakat for Fajar prayer instead of two. Will his deeds be acceptable in the view of Allah (SWT)? No will be the definite answer. Allah (SWT) has made every act according to His own wish. We cannot change it according to our wishes no matter how much purer our intentions may be to perform it. If a person does anything with his own wish, he will be considered out of Islam at once.

Along with the purity of intentions, the strict following of the Shari'ah is also necessarily required for the recommendation of Allah (SWT) and for His rewards.

A group of companions came to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) home, they inquired about the living style of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) after listening about it, they inspired and one of them said he would fast for the rest of his life, one said I would pray all night for every single day of his life, one claimed to remain single in his life. When the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) when listened to their wows He (PBUH) became distressed and His (PBUH) face turned red and forbade them to perform these deeds and led them a balanced way of life which is His (PBUH) Sunnah.

The Concept of Biddah

An act that looks like Sha'riah, proof of which does not exist in the Quran and Sunnah, doing it with the intention to get nearer to Allah (SWT) and to seek reward from Allah (SWT) is known as a Biddah. Every biddah is going astray, and every astray is in hellfire. Similarly, Fiqh (jurisprudence) is the knowledge of extracting the laws and provisions from the Quran and Sunnah. We must and have to perform the authentic acts endorsed by Shar'iah only.

Once Hazrat Jibrael (AS) came and asked the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) when would the hour (death) come? Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: "Allah (SWT) knows better about it. He (PBUH) mentioned some signs about it".

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "Whoever does any action that is not in accordance with this matter of ours (Islam), Will have it rejected." ***[Sahih Muslim]***

In our society, people named different things with different backgrounds as a religion and has made it sacred because they never got through the authentic books, refused to listen to the learned men, prohibited the reciting Quran daily has turned them to this level.

Tazkiyyah – The Purification of Heart (A)

Tazkiyyah is the process of purification of the heart/self. In the Quran, Allah (SWT) has sworn multiple times, which show the importance of His claim/statement which comes after swearing. And mostly, after swearing, He talked about the tazkiyyah. As in Surah Ash-Shams after swearing, He said,

"Successful is he, who purifies himself and destroyed is he who destroys himself". [Surah Ash-Shams: 9-10]

Scholars use two words for purification, one is tazkiyyah and the other is tasfeeya. There is a slight difference between the two of them. Tasfeeya means to clean. When a person starts sinning and sins are just on the surface of his heart, then tasfeeya can clean his heart by just stopping him from the sins, but if a person is very much sinful that his sins have penetrated to his heart then to eradicate the sins from his heart, tazkiyyah is required.

Allah (SWT) says,

"Successful is he, who purifies himself; And remembers the name of his Lord and prays." [Surah Al-A'la: 14-15]

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said that, "there is a piece of flesh in your body if that is good, everything is good, but if that is bad then everything is bad" then he said, "it is your heart".

One of the scholars, Ibn al Qayyim said, "that your heart is like a cooking pot and the tongue is a spoon that takes out the stuff which is cooking inside".

Center of Consciousness

- Our spiritual heart resides in our physical heart. Allah (SWT) has used the word Qalb in Quran on different places. E.g. Allah (SWT) says,

  "They have hearts wherewith they understand not". [Surah Al-Araf: 179]
- In many heart transplants, not only the organ transplanted in another body but also some of the emotions associated with that heart transplanted to the recipient by the donor.
- Our hearts start beating before even our brain function is established.
  Just as the brain sends a message to the heart, the heart also sends messages to the brain.
- Our heart also holds memories.
- Also sometimes, we make decisions based on our heart.
- Across different cultures, A heart is known to have different metaphors. e.g He stole my heart. So a heart can be metaphorically stolen. Etc.

Quranic Concept of Heart

Allah (SWT) says in the Quran,

"The Day where neither wealth nor sons will benefit. Except him who brings to Allah a sound (clean) heart". [Surah Ash-Shua'ra: 88-89]

Allah (SWT) wants us to purify us from inside because, from this hidden delve of our heart, our actions emerge.

Types of People

There are three types of people that Allah (SWT) mentions in Surah Baqarah. In the first 5 ayahs of Surah Baqarah, Allah (SWT) talks about the believers and in the next two ayahs 6 & 7, Allah (SWT) talks about the disbelievers and then in next 13 ayahs, Allah (SWT) talks about the 3rd category of people and introduce them in a way, ***"In their heart is a disease and Allah has increased their disease."*** These ayahs are regarding hypocrites.

Allah (SWT) wants our heart to be Qalb-e-Saleem that's why he mentioned 13 ayahs in Surah Baqarah about the hypocrites thus emphasizing the importance to remove the diseases from our hearts.

Blind Hearts

Allah (SWT) says in Quran,

"Verily, it is not the eyes that grow blind, but it is the hearts which are in the chests that grow blind". [Surah Al-Hajj: 46]

When one loses Baseerah (the ability to see what things they are) then it means their hearts have grown blind and one can have blind eyes in a way that he forgets that this life is temporary, and he has to be resurrected one day. He forgets about the absolute facts of life. One of the absolute facts of life is death. Sometimes, eyesight stays alright, but hearts get blind.

When a person commits a sin, a black spot emerges on his heart. And if a person keeps doing it, the whole heart will turn black and dark. Similarly, if a person starts doing good deeds, a white spot will undo a black spot on his heart and in the same way his whole heart will turn into a white and shiny heart if he keeps doing good deeds.

The Heart's Nourishment

"Those who believed, and whose hearts find rest in the remembrance of Allah, Verily, in the remembrance of Allah do hearts find rest". [Surah Ar-Rad: 28]

So, if our heart is looking for purifying and contentment, the best thing is to start with the remembering Allah (SWT).

Two Major Diseases of Heart

Although there are hundreds of diseases of heart two of them are considered as major diseases which can corrupt our hearts while other diseases are considered as the by-product of these diseases.

1. Shubuhaat / Doubts
2. Shahawaat / Base desires

Shubuhaat / Doubts

Doubts about Islam, Allah (SWT), whether we will get our rizaq (living) or not, doubts regarding the future. Because if our heart is in doubts, it can never be nafs-ul-mutmaeena. It makes one's heart very restless. If one has doubts about Allah (SWT), then his faith goes away and if faith goes then everything goes away.

Shahawaat / Base Desires

There are two basic desires of human beings.

1. To feed themselves
2. To have relations with other human beings

When lust or greed take over these desires then one can transgress the limits of Allah (SWT).

Properties of People of Heaven & Hell

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: "Do you know the things which most commonly brings people into Paradise? It is fear of Allah (SWT) and good character. Do you know what most commonly brings people into Hell? It is the two hollow things: the mouth and the private parts." ***[Tirmidhi, 4832]***

People who purify themselves always have good character (Husn-e-Khulq). Taqwa (piety) and good character are the qualities of the people of paradise. While people of hell have obnoxious tongue and they are indulging in vulgarity.

Selling the Deen

"Those are they who have bought the life of this world at the price of the Hereafter. Their torment shall not be lightened nor shall they be helped." [Surah Al-Baqarah: 86]

For example, anger. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) has promised the house in paradise to those who control their anger. Those who don't control their anger and take the temporary pleasure of this life, lose the gifts of akhirah.

Reality of Dunya

"If I were to give everyone what they requested, that would not decrease what I have, any more that a needle decreases the sea if put into it." ***[Sahih Muslim, Tirimdhi, Ibn Majah]***

The Prophet Mohammad (SWT) said, "If the world was equivalent to a wing of a Mosquito in the sight of Allah, He would not give a disbeliever a single drop to drink from it." ***[Jami At-Tirmidhi]***

This world has no reality in comparison to the hereafter.

Allah (SWT) said in the Quran,

"But No! You prefer the life of this world. Although the Hereafter is better and more lasting." [Surah al-Ala: 16-7]

As an Ummah, we have corrupted ourselves as well. Our outer look is very attractive but from inside we are corrupted. Unless, we won't perform tazkiyyah of ourselves and as an Ummah, corruption and looting will increase day by day and also, we will fall as an Ummah.

Process of Change

"Verily! Allah will <u>not</u> change the condition of a people as long as they do not change what is within themselves". [Surah Ar-Rad: 11]

Gandhi said, "Be the change you want to see in the world. So, the process of change starts from our own self".

The first command to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) given by Allah (SWT) was ***"Iqra means Read"***. The second command was ***"O you who wrapped up in a garment, stand up to pray in the night"***. Then another command, ***"O you who wrapped up in a garment, stand up and warn people."*** So, first do it by yourself, build your connection with Allah (SWT) and then warn or give Dawah to other people.

Tazkiyyah - Purification of the Heart (B)

Process of Purification of Heart

We need to discuss the process of how to purify the hearts. The process of purification of the heart is a continuous process till death. We cannot say that our hearts are purified and they do not need any more purification.

The Diseases of the Heart

Like our bodies, our hearts have diseases to fall prey to them. They may include desires, greed, lust, envy, love, anger, hypocrisy, debates and show off etc. Some of them are more severe than others. The path of Allah (SWT) is easy to follow and we will reach the ultimate success by following it. Every other path is full of problems. When we follow Allah (SWT)'s path, Allah (SWT) makes it easy for us to lead on it. We have no knowledge about the decree of Allah (SWT).

Allah (SWT) has distributed everything among people with His own wish. Human always desires to get everything for him without knowing the benefits and harmful effects of those things. People become envious of others if they do not get what they want while the others have it. Allah (SWT) mentioned the events of Prophet Musa (AS) and Prophet Khizar (AS) in Surah Al-Kahf. Prophet Khizar (AS) broke the plank of a boat in which they were sitting, later he killed a little boy without any major crime; and finally, he built a wall for the orphans.

Prophet Musa (AS) inquired about the reasons behind all these unexpected events to which Prophet Khizar (AS) replied one by one. Prophet Khizar (AS) replied that boat with broken plank would actually save them from the wrath of the king who would confiscate the boats and imprison the sailors. He said I killed the boy because he would become the most terrible man and serial killer in the world. He would probably take his family to kufr. Therefore, Allah (SWT) wanted he died. Allah (SWT) mentioned that every human being will be tested by fear, hunger, happiness, sorrows and with otherworldly problems. Allah (SWT) has a full picture of us all, but we see a small perspective.

Love of anything in this world other than Allah (SWT) is considered as a disease. People have feelings of love for each other and they usually transgress the limits of Allah (SWT). Allah (SWT) said, those who believe are extreme in the love of Allah (SWT). Therefore, liking someone may lead to disobeying Allah (SWT). At this, one needs to draw a line that my love for Allah (SWT) is more than this person.

Problems of Muslim Ummah

There are 1.8 billion among the total populations of the world. We have best forces, universities, wealth, atomic powers and natural resources. But we are in the very terrible conditions in the world.

Allah (SWT) mentioned:

"Verily! Allah (SWT) will not change the condition of a people as long as they do not change what is within themselves." [Surah Ar-Rad: 11]

There are categories of believers and the pious people, starting from Muslim, Momin, Muttaqqi and finally the Mohsin. The guidance lies in the Qur'an for those who have Taqwa (piety).

Types of Fear of Allah (SWT)

There are different types of fears of Allah (SWT). The first one is Khushu, standing before Allah (SWT) with complete attentiveness. The second one is Raha, it is like you get afraid of something so quickly and you easily get back to your normal condition. For example, Prophet Ibrahim (AS) felt Raha, when he cooked the best calf for two travelers who came to see him when he presented them food they did not eat it. At that moment, they said we are angles and sent by Allah (SWT). Another type is Khauf, Allah (SWT) mentioned that your hearts will be in your throats with fear on the Day of Judgment. There is another type of fear, you just know about it, but do not do anything against it. Similarly, Taqwa of Allah (SWT) is the type of fear that makes you change yourself. It makes us realize and prohibit ourselves from sins. Taqwa is for the change of the state of human beings.

Allah (SWT) said:

"O you who believe! Fear Allah (SWT) and be with those who are true".

[Surah At-Taubah: 119]

It is mandatory for us to be muttaqis (pious) and strive hard up to our capacities to be muttaqis (pious). And also, we need to be with the true people because a company of pious people will have its effects on us. Imam Ghazali said, "A bad friend is worse than Satan". Therefore, Taqwa is like a flame in the heart of the person, you live in the company of a muttaqi person (pious), will also be influenced by that flame.

"Our Lord! Let not our hearts deviate (from the truth) after You have guided us. And grant us mercy from You. Truly You are the Bestower". [Surah Al-Imran: 8]

The Saved Sect

Allah (SWT) says in Quran,

"Hold fast to the Rope of Allah all of you together and do not differ."
[Surah Al-Imraan: 103]

Allah (SWT) says at another place,

"Be not of the Mushrikeen, of those who split up their religion and became sects, each rejoicing in that which is with it". [Surah Ar-Room: 30-32]

The Prophet (PBUH) also described them in the following terms: "My ummah will split into seventy-three sects, all of whom will be in Hell except one group." They said: Who are they, O Messenger of Allah? He(PBUH) said: "(Those who follow) that which I and my companions follow." This hadith has authetic chain of transmission which can be seen in Sunan Abu Dawud, Masnad Ahmad, Sahih al-Tirmidhi, Masnad Hakim and Takhreej al-Ihya by Iraqi. Ibn kathir and Ibn Hajar also quoted this hadith.

According to the hadith, it is very much clear that all the sects are Muslims and believers of Islam. The one sect who will follow the Quran and Sunnah strictly will go to paradise straight away. The other sects will be in hellfire, stay there for a certain period of time and then will go to paradise except for the one who will be in hell fire forever. This is the sect who polluted their beliefs with shirk.

The Noble Messenger Mohammad (PBUH) has also informed us that the Jews and the Christians split up into many sects and that the Muslims will split up more than them, so these groups will be subjected to entering the Fire due to their deviations and their distancing themselves from the Book of their Lord, and from the Sunnah of their Prophet.

We have been informed that the one Saved Sect from them will enter Paradise and they are the Jamaa'ah, those who cling to the Book of Allah (SWT) and the authentic Sunnah and the practice of the Companions of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

This is important for us to be strict in the basics of Islam and do not deviate from the straight path.

From Ibn Mas'ood: "The Messenger of Allah (PBUH) drew for us a straight line. Then he (PBUH) said: 'This is Allah's straight Path.' Then he (PBUH) drew lines on the right and left of it. Then he (PBUH) said, 'These are the paths, there is not a path amongst them except a devil's call to it.' Then he (PBUH) recited the ayah from the Quran,

"And, [moreover], this is My path, which is straight, so follow it; and do not follow [other] ways, for you will be separated from His way. This has He instructed you that you may become righteous." [Surah Al-Anaam: 6/153]

When people drift away from the main body of Islam and develop their own approaches to understand the commandments of the Quran, then there is a fear to lose their way.

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: "I am leaving amongst you two things, you will never go astray as long as you cling to them: The Book of Allah (SWT) and my Sunnah. They will not separate from each other until you meet me at the Lake." ***[Sahih: Related by al-Hakim from Abu Hurayrah. It was authenticated by al-Albaani in Takhrijul-Mishkat (186)]***

Once people argued with Hazrat Ibn Abbas (RA) that Hazrat Umar (RA) was performing Umrah in a different way as was told by the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). He (PBUH) said: "I fear that the stones will descend upon you from the sky" because they were quoting Hazrat Abu Bakar (RA) and Hazrat Umar (RA) as compare to the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH).

When people prefer to follow others than Sunnah, though do it in love of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and to please Allah (SWT), they change their direction slightly, and then gradually turn into a new sect. These people distinguish themselves by different names and characters, for example, Khwarijies in the era of Hazrat Uthman (RA). They believe in Allah (SWT), Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), Holy Quran, but they follow other believers to get more reward and barakah.

The only thing to unite the Muslim Ummah is believing Allah (SWT), the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and the Holy Quran. A Muslim who may live anywhere in the world is a member of Muslim Ummah.

"O mankind, fear your Lord, who created you from one soul and created from it its mate and dispersed from both of them many men and women. And fear Allah, through whom you ask one another, and the wombs. Indeed, Allah is ever, over you, an Observer." [Surah An-Nisa: 1]

Allah (SWT) commands to unite. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) also described Muslim Ummah as one body and people as different parts of this body. But Muslims are separated on petty issues which are meaningless or not beneficial for the Ummah. Rather, they are divided into sects on such issues. This disunity resulted in intellectual decline, falsification, the decline of brotherhood and sacrifice. Instead of supporting each other, Muslims involve in misconceptions which create anarchy in the society. It also makes the state weak and enemies get control over it. Muslims should realize and believe that the unity of the Ummah will be helpful to move forward in this world as well as in the hereafter. They can support each other in the fields of Education, Trade, Technology, Economy and Safety of the Muslim world.

Lawful Earning in Perspective of Islam

Whenever we talk about earning, we must keep one essential point in mind that we should be focused Akhirah, which means that life is not just about making money, it is more than that.

Our purpose of education should be more than just earning only. In previous societies, people used to seek education to be more enlightened, knowledgeable, sophisticated, cultured etc. They seek education to improve their character and conduct.

Nowadays the focus of education is not to make us civilized and decent human being but it is rather to make us the money earning machine. We are basically taught how to comply with authority and to work under people, etc. Only rizq takers put their belief in Allah (SWT) and start their own business.

When we are focused akhirah, we realize that our purpose of life is not to earn money by hook or crook, but our real purpose is to get to paradise and earning halal rizq can be a way to get to the paradise.

Best Type of Earning

- The Messenger of Allah (PBUH) was asked what type of earning was best and he replied: "A man's work with his hand, and every business transaction which is approved." ***[At-Tirmidhi, 2783]***

- Margaret Fuller said, "Men for the sake of getting a living forget to live."

When our motive behind earning is akhirah then we also take care of our family, our work and ourselves because our bodies have rights on ourselves.

- The Messenger of Allah (PBUH) said, "If you were to rely on Allah (SWT) as He should be relied on, He would provide for you as He provides for the birds. They go out early in the morning hungry and return in the evening, full." ***[At-Tirmidhi; Graded Hassan]***

One must go out for halal earning, Allah (SWT) will provide him as He provides for the birds. So, one must make a move to get lawful earning, sitting and doing nothing won't take us anywhere. Allah (SWT) bestow His blessings upon whom who makes a right choice of lawful source of income.

- The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: "Allah (SWT) has appointed an angel in the womb, and the angel says…'O Lord! A male or a female? O Lord! wretched or blessed? What will his livelihood be? What will his age be?' The angel writes all this while the child is in the womb of its mother." ***[Sahih Bukhari]***

So, we should not be stressed about earning. We should work on our akhirah. This will also help us in getting lawful earning.

- The Messenger of Allah (PBUH) said, “Even if the son of Adam were to flee from his rizq like he flees from death, his rizq would still reach him just like his death will reach him.” ***[Silsilah Ahadeeth Saheeha (952)]***

It means that our livelihood chases us just like our death chases us. Rizq means all the stuff we consumed.

Job or Business - Which is More Suitable?

The difference between job and business is that when we do the job, we are working for someone, while when we do business we are creating jobs for other people.

A man came to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and asked for money. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, “I won’t give you money, but will help to run a business for you”. Then He asked this person what do you have in your house. He said I have a few pots and pans in my home.

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) asked him to sell them, he sold them for 2 or 3 dinars and he got the blade of an axe, Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) gave him a stick and he put that stick into the blade of the axe and asked this person to cut wood and sell it, so that is your business from now. He started to provide services to other people with just one tool and within just one day, he was able to buy those pots and pans he sold in the market. He then started to provide his family and himself.

In Islam, business is more recommended than jobs because in business our tawakal (faith) on Allah (SWT) is more involved. Imam Abu Hanifa was also a merchant of loose clothing.

Professional Life

In Islam, it is the responsibility of a man to provide the living to his dependents, if he is not providing for his dependents then he is sinful for that. A woman can work, but her all earning only belongs to her and she can do whatever she wants to do with it. But whatever man earns, there is a share for his wife, for his children, for the house and for himself.

The problem arises when man and woman swap their roles. E.g woman becomes the bread earner and man becomes the home maker.

Earning Can Be an Act of Worship

Earning a livelihood can be an act of worship if we earn in a lawful (halal) way. When a man came to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and He (PBUH) told him that if you earn money to provide for your parents then this is an act of worship, if you earn rizq to feed your family, then this is an act of worship and if you earn rizq for yourself so that you don't want to beg others for your food/money, even that's an act of worship.

Earn Halal and Spend Halal (Lawful)

The Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) mentioned a man having journeyed far, disheveled and dusty, he spreads out his hands to the sky (saying): "O Lord! O, Lord!" - while his food is Haram, his drink is Haram, his clothing is Haram, and his nourishment is Haram, so how can his dua be answered! ***[Sahih Muslim]***

This shows that the person who is living on haram, his dua will not be accepted. There are 4 conditions when dua mostly accepted.

- Dua of an oppressed even if he is a disbeliever.
- Traveler's dua
- The one who raises his hands towards the sky for dua – Hadith says that Allah (SWT) feels shy to return him empty handed
- The one who calls Allah (SWT) with His beautiful names

In the above hadith, the person is fulfilling the criteria for the acceptance of dua even then Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said that why Allah (SWT) should listen to him as he earned haram.

The Messenger of Allah (PBUH) said: "A body nourished on Haram sustenance (rizq) will not enter paradise." ***[Sunan at-Tirmidhi]***

Allah (SWT) said in Quran,

"Indeed, Allah gives rizq to the one, whom he wants without accountability".
[Ale Imran 3:37]

Why Do We Work?

Allah (SWT) says,

"And whosoever fears Allah (SWT), He (Allah) will make a way out for him (from every difficulty). And He will provide him from (sources) he could never imagine".
[Surah At-Talaq: 2-3]

Business Ethics in Islam

Intrinsically Business should not follow the Haram as well as if the business is Halal, then one's behavior could make it haram, so both ways need to be taken care of.

There are certain factors in business ethics which should be taken care of in order to avoid the involvement of Haram in our business.

1. Hiring & Promotion – Must be on merit
2. Nature of Business – Must not be haram
3. Customer Relationship – Must be taken care equally
4. Employee Relationship – Must avoid the favoritism
5. Competitor – Must not bash competitor
6. Misuse of Assets – Must be avoided
7. Environmental Pollution – Any business hurting the environment must be avoided

Fiqh and Shariah (A)

This lecture deals with the difference between the Fiqh and Shariah and how to interpret the commands/laws of Allah (SWT) that he has given us to be followed.

There are six basic rules in Fiqh or Islamic law.

Rule 1: Enter into Islam Completely

Allah (SWT) said in the Quran, "O We believe, Enter into Islam completely". So, for Muslims, it is important to enter in Islam from the tops of their heads to the tips of their toes so that they are completely submerged in Islam. It's the first and very easy law to understand.

Rule 2: Every Act of Worship is Haram

Except if we've got proof of it from the Quran or the Sunnah.

So, we cannot do any act of worship unless it is approved by Allah (SWT) and Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Therefore, any act of worship which is not approved by Allah (SWT) and Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) will be called "Biddah". It will become an innovation in Islam.

When some people asked the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) that they will offer Salah all night and will not marry the whole of their lives and fast all day and devote ourselves to us then the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) face turned red and He said, I have more Taqwa (piety) than you, the one who moves away from my Sunnah is not from me.

Rule 3: Everything from the Worldly Affairs is Halal

In this case, everything from the worldly has been made permissible except for which we got the proof from the Quran and Sunnah to stop and to stay away. For example, if somebody will ask that wearing a jacket is impermissible in Islam as it was never worn by the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and his companions then we can ask him to bring any proof from Quran or Sunnah where it is being declared as impermissible to wear.

Being not used by the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and his companions doesn't make a thing impermissible. Similarly, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) might have not eaten rice in his life, then it doesn't make rice as haram food.

Rule 4: A Worldly Matter is Placed into one of Five Categories

1. Farz – It is mandatory, if we don't do then we will be sinful. For example, prayers 5 times a day is farz, if we don't offer prayers then we will be sinful.
2. Mustahab – It is originated from the word Hub, which means muhabba, means this act was being loved by Allah (SWT) and Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) so it's not farz, but it is highly recommended and preferable and we will get extra reward for it but if we don't do then we are not sinful.
3. Mubah – Means doing or not doing won't make a much difference. There is no reward or sin for doing it. E.g Eating an apple is not sinful nor rewarding act.

Scholars of Fiqh are very intelligent people as they have complete knowledge of Tafseer, hadith, opinions of the companions, asbab UL nasal, knowledge of Asma wa Rijaal. And based on this knowledge, they tell us what Allah (SWT) wants? They have to look at all the evidence from the Quran and Sunnah and tell Allah's (SWT) will. They tell us how the Shariah should be acted upon? Like how to pray? How to fast? What will invalidate our prayer? What will invalidate our fast?

4. Makrooh – It is from the word Karahiyat means something from which we feel disgusted, these acts are not likened by Allah (SWT) e.g. Eating onions and then go to the masjid is makrooh. If we do a makrooh act, then we are not sinful, but leaving a makrooh act is being rewarded.
5. Haram – If we do haram acts, then it is sinful, but if we leave them then it is rewarding worthy.

Rule 5: Things are Made Haram or Makrooh Using the Quran and Sunnah or the Scholars Deducing through Analogy

Sometimes we have clear evidence that one thing is haram and sometimes with that analogy, other things can be made haram too. For example, when scholars find out the alcohol is coming with different names, and they find out that alcohol is haram for its effects and intoxication. It clouds one's judgment and actually takes you away from who you are. There is a hadith of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), that's what intoxicates or haram in large quantity, even a small quantity of that is haram. Even one sip of that is haram.

What is harmful to our body is also impermissible in Shariah. Allah (SWT) said, do not kill yourself with your hands. So, any act which takes your life in danger is impermissible in Islam, whether it's a drug or a suicide.

So, after the Quran and Sunnah, Scholars can deduce through analogy and that should also be followed.

Rule 6: Make Things Easy

Make things easy for people and don't make them difficult. Hazrat Ayesha (RA) said that whenever a matter brought in front of the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), He used to pick the easier of the two options as long as both were permissible in Shariah.

When we are traveling, we are allowed to shorten or join the prayer.

Watch Out for These Activities

Such gatherings should be avoided where these activities are involved:

1. Intoxicants – every kind of intoxicants whether alcohol, weed, heroin etc. is impermissible
2. Gambling – Even bet on games is impermissible
3. Free- Mixing (male & female) – Allah (SWT) said, don't go near Zina.
4. Wastage of time – Any game which doesn't have any purpose and wastes your time is not appreciated.
5. Compromise on Modesty – Any activity in which male or female has to compromise his / her modesty is impermissible
6. Extravagance – Spending a lot of money unnecessarily
7. Fortune telling – Every kind of fortune telling whether its palm reading, tarot reading etc. is impermissible
8. Mocking Islam – Making fun of Islam in any way is impermissible
9. Causing Harm – Anything which can harm ourselves is not respected

Fiqh and Shariah (B)

Introduction

There are six rules of Fiqh, we need to follow and we need to see what things are permissible and impermissible in terms of worldly affairs based on those six rules of Fiqh. Allah (SWT) mentioned not only to gather Muslims of the world, but also no Muslims to come to common terms that exist among all of us.

Common Terms

Allah (SWT) says in Quran,

"O People of the book! Come to the common terms as between us and you: that we worship none but Allah (SWT); that we associate no partners with Him; that we erect not from among ourselves Lords and patrons other than Allah (SWT). If then they turn back, say: Bear witness that we (at least) are Muslims (bowing to Allah(SWT)' will)".
[Surah Aal-e-Imran 3: 64]

In Christianity, Pope is considered as an authority and he can make changes in their legislations. But in Islam, no scholars have such a liberty to make any changes in the Quran and shariah.

Deen vs. Shariah

The following are the differences between Deen and Shariah.

Deen

Many Prophets (AS) appeared to guide the people towards Allah (SWT) before the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). For example, Hazrat Noah (AS), Hazrat Musa (AS) and Hazrat Esa (AS) had the same and single message to spread to ***'Believe in One God, associate no partners with Him and follow the Messengers (AS)'***. Hence, Deen remained the same for all humanity for centuries.

Shariah (Islamic Law)

Shariah is based on the Quran and Sunnah. It's quite general in nature and also known as the divine law. Shariah changed over the passage of time. For example, the sharia's of Hazrat Noah (AS) and Hazrat Musa (AS) were quite different from the Shariah of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) in many respects. A person can take the revenge for anything he has suffered from another person in the Shariah of Islam, although the forgiveness is more appreciable in the Islam, whereas in the Shariah of Hazrat Musa (AS), taking revenge was highly recommended. Similarly, the Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) did not like the act of Hazrat Umar (RA) reading

the pages of Torah instead of the Quran. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said if Hazrat Musa (AS) were alive He would have to follow Islam instead of His own shariah. Prophets (AS) were infallible and free from all kinds of sins. But in Israeliyaat, they have presented Prophets (AS) with very low repute. We cannot believe in them completely.

Fiqh vs. Shariah

Fiqh (Jurisprudence)

Fiqh is the application of shariah in specific conditions and circumstances. Fiqh has a capacity of change in it based on new evidences and an application which is known as Ijtihad. Also, the doors are opened to new deductions and interpretations in Fiqh.

Fiqh is the actual implementation of shariah upon our lives. Abu Hanifa was very careful about collecting Hadith, he once quoted that reject it at once if you found my provisions against Quran and Sunnah. A faqeeh has to see many aspects of issues to give fatwa about new and arising issues. For examples, how to establish prayer for an astronaut, how to find the Qibla while a person is traveling through an airplane? A woman should not talk to men in markets with gentle voices etc.

Shariah

Shariah is the divine law which is based on Quran and Sunnah and quite general in nature. Islamic Shariah involves every aspect of human life. Islamic Shariah defines how to adopt a way of life which is recommended by Islam starting from personal to social life. The scholars of Fiqh are more knowledgeable than other scholars. They need to understand and expertise many aspects of history, Quran, sharia and other subjects to make careful propositions of Islamic Fiqh.

History

After the Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH), there were four caliphs who ruled the Islamic state and their period of government is known as the caliphate. They were:

1. **Hazrat Abu Bakar ibn Abi Kehafa (RA)**
2. **Hazrat Umer Bin Khattab (RA)**
3. **Hazrat Usman Bin Uffan (RA)**
4. **Hazrat Ali Ibn e Abi Talib (RA)**

Imams of Fiqh

There are not only four Imams of fiqh in Islam but the four of them became very famous among Muslims and they are as under:

1. **Imam Abu Haneefa**
2. **Imam Malik**
3. **Imam Shafi'i**
4. **Imam Ahmed ibn Hanbal**

The students of these Imams were sharp that they published the works of their teachers which made them famous among people.

Science of Hadith

It is important to note that now, the Quran has been completely compiled, during the lifetime of the Holy Prophet Mohammad (PBUH). Later, Imam Bukhari, Muslim, Trimizi, Abu Dawood had done great work to collect the Ahadith. They worked on whatever information they had available at that time.

Imams

The Imams were great scholars of their time. They made the following points very clear:

1. They followed the madhab (religion) of the authentic Ahadith
2. They did not write their own opinion unless there was an ijma (unanimous decision)
3. They rejected it. If their opinion contradicted with the Quran and Sunnah

Allah (SWT) mentioned,

"O You who believe! Obey Allah (SWT) and obey the Messenger (PBUH) and those charged with authority (or knowledge). If they differ in anything, refer it to Allah (SWT) and His Messenger (PBUH), if you believe in Allah (SWT) and the Last Day: that is best, and most suitable for final determination". [Surah An-Nisa: 59]

Sectarianism

Allah (SWT) said,

"But they (men) have broken their religion among them into sects, each group rejoicing in what is what it (as its belief)". [Surah Al-Muminoon: 53]

Hazrat Hudhaifa bin Al-Yaman (RA) narrated that "the people used to ask Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) about the good, but I used to ask him about the evil lest I should be overtaken but them***". [Bukhari]***

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "Stick to the group of Muslims and their Imam. I said if there is neither a group of Muslims nor an Imam? He (PBUH) said, then turning away from all those sects even if you bit the roots of a tree till death overtakes you while you are that state".

Previous Messengers

Allah (SWT) mentioned about the Prophets (AS),

"He (Allah SWT) has ordained for you the same religion which He ordained for Noah (AS) and that which We have revealed to You (O Muhammad (PBUH)), and that which We ordained for Ibrahim (AS), Musa (AS) and Isa (AS) saying you should establish religion, and make no divisions (sects) in it. Intolerable for the Mushrikun, is that to which you call them. Allah (SWT) chooses for Himself whom He wills, and guides unto Himself who turns to Him in repentance and in obedience". [Surah Shuara:13-14]

At another place, Allah (SWT) said,

"Ibrahim (AS) was neither a Jew nor a Christian, but He was a true Muslim and He was not of Al- Mushrikun". [Surah Al-Imran: 67]

Allah (SWT) said,

"Then when Isa (AS) came to know of their disbelief, he said: Who will be my helpers in Allah (SWT)'s Cause? Al- Hawariyyun (the disciples) said: We are the helpers of Allah (SWT), We believe in Allah (SWT), and bear witness that we are Muslims".
[Surah Al-Imran: 52]

Muslims

Allah (SWT) said,

"And strive hard in Allah (SWT)'s Cause as you ought to strive. He has chosen you, and has not laid upon you in religion any hardship, it is the religion of your father Ibrahim (AS). It is He Who has named you Muslims both before and in this (revelation); that the Messenger (PBUH)may be a witness over you and you be witness over mankind! So, perform As-Salat, give Zakat and hold fast to Allah (SWT). He is your Maula (Guardian), What an excellent Maula and what an excellent Helper!". [Surah Al-Hajj: 78]

Allah (SWT) said**,**

"And who is better in speech than one who invites (men) to Allah (SWT), and does righteous deeds and says. I am one of the Muslims". [Surah Fussilat: 33]

Allah (SWT) said,

"Say, Verily, I am commanded to serve Allah (SWT) with sincere devotion; and I am commanded to be the first of those who are Muslims".
[Surah Az-Zumar: 11-12]

Allah (SWT) says in Quran,

"O People of the book! Come to the common terms as between us and you: that we worship none but Allah (SWT); that we associate no partners with Him; that we erect not from among ourselves Lords and patrons other than Allah (SWT). If then they turn back, say: Bear witness that we (at least) are Muslims (bowing to Allah(SWT)' will)."
[Surah Al-Imran: 64]

Laws of Allah (SWT) and Effects of Sins (A)

Laws of Allah (SWT)

There are two types of laws of Allah (SWT).

1. Visible or Instantaneous
2. Invisible or Delayed

Visible or Instantaneous Laws

Visible laws are related to the physical world, e.g. law of gravity, that whatever goes up must come down or whenever we touch fire, it will burn us and also it is impossible to walk on water. These are also called the laws of nature and Allah (SWT).

Invisible or Delayed Laws

There are some laws of Allah (SWT) which are invisible or their response is delayed. We can't see them instantly. E.g. telling lie is like breaking Allah's (SWT) laws, but the response to that violence might not be instantaneous. Similarly, eating haram foods is a forbidden act as well as engaging in haram relationships, the response of such violence of laws of Allah (SWT) may not be instantaneous but it affects the person who commits such violence. So most of the time, we earn our misfortune by ourselves by breaking the laws of Allah (SWT).

Cause of Our Troubles

Allah (SWT) says,

"And whatever misfortune befalls you, it is because of what your hands have earned. And He pardons much." [Surah Ash-Shura:30]

Whenever we do wrong deeds, either we should wait for our punishment or make Tauba (repentance) before the arrival of punishment or difficulties to our way. Because mostly we earn these troubles by our sins. Sooner we make repentance for our sins faster our difficulties or troubles will disappear.

In bad times, we should do sabr (patience) and in good times we should do shukar (thankful) to Allah (SWT). He has given us countless blessings like our eyes, hands, ears, nose, legs and many more, but the question is, are we using His blessings for the right purpose?

Astaghfaar is the key to wipe our sins, thus making our lives easy. Repentance evaporates our sins and difficulties due to those sins.

Prophets of Allah (SWT) don't commit sin, but they can make mistakes as Quran reports the incident of Hazrat Adam (AS) that's how he went near the forbidden tree and How Allah (SWT) took him from Jannah, then Hazrat Adam (AS) realized his mistake and Quran marked his words for the mankind that O Allah (SWT), I have wronged myself and you will not forgive me I will be one of the losers. Similarly, Hazrat Younus (AS) was kept in the belly of a whale for his misjudgment and there he repented.

Importance of Astaghfaar / Repentance

Hasan Al-Basri was one of Ta'abaeen and very righteous man and scholar. Once One of his student Rabi bin Sabi was sitting with him and they saw that four people came to him one by one. The first one complained about the lack of rain in his area and asked about any wazifa for it to end the situation of dry season/drought. Hasan Al-Basri told him to do astaghfaar he said okay and left. The second person came and said that we have poverty and hunger in our area, can you tell me some wazifa to end this situation of hunger. Hasan Al-Basri said that go back and do astaghfaar. He left as well. The third man came and said that I need a son I have a land and I need an heir to take care of my property after me. Hasan Al-Basri asked him that If you want a son, go back and ask astaghfaar. The fourth guy came, he said I have a garden with trees, but they don't bear fruit on them. Hasan Al-Basri also asked him to ask astaghfaar. His student Rabi bin Sabi seated near him was surprised and asked Hasan Al-Basri that why have you asked all four of them the same wazifa to ask astaghfaar for their different problems? Hasan Al-Basri said that I have not said it from my own account, whatever I said is from the book of Allah (SWT) and then he narrated the ayahs from Surah Nooh. When Nooh (AS) said to his people, " Ask forgiveness from your Lord; Verily, He is oft-forgiving. He will send rain to you in abundance. And give you increase in wealth and children, and bestow on you gardens and bestow on you rivers". (while people of Nooh (AS) were committing the sin of shirk which is the biggest zulm (violence), Hazrat Nooh (AS) said that if you make repentance then even this crime will be forgiven by Allah (SWT) and will be bestowed with His blessings).

Hadith of Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) from Ibne Maja

This hadith basically explains the 5 causes – effects principles.

- If fornication should become widespread, you should realize that this has never happened without new diseases befalling the people which their forebears never suffered.
- If people should begin to cheat in weighing out goods, you should realize that this has never happened without drought and famine befalling the people, and their rulers oppressing them.
- If people should withhold Zakat, you should realize that this has never happened without the rain being stopped from falling; and was it not for the animals' sake, it would never rain again.

- If people should break their covenant with Allah (SWT) & His Messenger (PBUH), you should realize that he has never happened without Allah (SWT) sending an enemy against them to take some of their possessions by force.
- If the leaders do not govern according to the Book of Allah (SWT), you should realize that this has never happened without Allah (SWT), making them into groups and making them fight one another.

Other Effects of Sins

Allah (SWT) says,

"And thus We set some wrongdoers on some others because of what they used to commit". [Surah Al-Anaam:129]

So if we have been now caught in a situation where oppressors are ruling on us then it is due to our own deeds.

At other place Allah (SWT) said in the Quran,

"Thus he (Fir'aun) fooled (and misled) his people, and they obeyed him. Verily, they were ever a people who were Fasiqun (sinful & disobedient to Allah)." [Surah Az-Zukhruf:54]

These people were fooled by Fir'aun because those people were also sinners so they were the cause of their own pitiful situation.

Noam Chomsky said that the general population doesn't know what's going on in the world and it doesn't even know that it doesn't know.

Imam Shafi'i said: "I complained to Wakee about the weakness of my memory. So, he ordered me to abandon sins".

The Secret of Fighting Against Immorality

"Verily, the prayer prevents from immorality (indecency) and evil wicked deeds. And the remembering of Allah is greater indeed". [Surah Al-Ankaboot:45]

Laws of Allah (SWT) and Effects of Sins (B)

Introduction

Allah (SWT) says,

"Verily, the prayer prevents from immorality and evil wicked deeds. And the remembering of Allah (SWT) is greater indeed". [Surah Al-Ankaboot: 45]

Prayer is one of those things which purify us. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "Do you think a man would be dirty who takes a bath five times a day in the river flowing in front of his home? They said No. He (PBUH) said prayer is like this to a man, which makes him purer from inside. He (PBUH) again said: Every intoxicant is forbidden. Verily, Allah (SWT) the Exalted and Majestic, made a covenant to those who drank intoxicants to make them drink Tinat al Khabal. They said: Allah's Messenger Mohammad (PBUH) what is Tinat-al-Khabal? He (PBUH) said: It is the sweat of an inhabitant of Hell or the discharge of an inhabitant of Hell (Muslim). Hazrat Umme Salma (RA) stated that Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said: Someone who eats or drinks from a silver or golden vessels is gulping Hellfire into his belly. ***[Bukhari/Muslim]***

Seeking Allah (SWT)'s Pleasure

Allah (SWT)'s Messenger (PBUH) said, "Whoever sought the pleasure of Allah (SWT) though it was displeasing to the people, then Allah (SWT) became pleased with him and will make the people pleased with him. And whoever sought the pleasure of people, though it was disappointing to Allah (SWT) then Allah (SWT) becomes displeased with him and make the people displeased with him". ***[Tirmidhi]***

We should not involve ourselves in those activities like marriage ceremonies, valima gatherings and other meetings in which no provisions of shariah are taken care of. To please Allah (SWT), we should avoid such gathering and prohibit ourselves to be a part of them. If people get annoyed by our behavior, we should not take care of their behavior. We should advise them not to do those acts which are Haram and sinful according to Shariah.

Live Longer

Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) said, "Whoever would like his rizk (provision) to be increased and his life to be extended, should uphold the ties of kinship". ***[Bukhari/Muslim]***

We have been made to establish the best relationships with our kin. We should not be hostile or having bad intentions with our relatives. Our relatives have rights upon us, whenever you see a relative coming towards you, firstly, say him Salam, inquire about his health, offer your

services for his help if he needs may be physical or financial, make dua for them for their guidance and blessings and fifth right is to give them gifts worth from your heart.
Our goal must be to make prayers for our relatives for their hadayah and prosperity in this world and Hereafter. We should participate in their celebrations to make them happy, but we should warn them about the anger of Allah (SWT) about the sinful acts and forbidden events if they are involved in.

We are prohibited to get involved in such acts of pranks and amusements which can cause insult to others. Hazrat Nouman (RA) was one of the companions, he came with a basket of very rare fruits from Lebanon to Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) and knocked the door. He said, it's a gift for You. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) accepted it and a moment later the owner of the fruit came at the door and asked for the money. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) called for Hazrat Nouman (RA) and inquired about it, he replied: I wanted to present this gift to You but was out of money so I took this basket and gave it to you and told the owner to take the money from you. Prophet Mohammad (PBUH) smiled at it and paid the owner for the fruits.

Getting Help from Allah (SWT)

In Quran, it is mentioned that,

"Verily, Allah (SWT) will help those who help His (cause). Truly, Allah (SWT) is All-Strong, All-Mighty. [Al-Hajj:40]

Allah (SWT) mentioned at another place in Quran,

"Those who, if We give them power in land (they) enjoin <u>As-Salat</u>. To pay <u>Zakat</u> and they <u>enjoin what is good</u> and <u>forbid what is evil</u>. And with Allah (SWT) rests the end of (all) matters.". [Al-Hajj:40]

Duas Not Accepted

Allah (SWT)'s Messenger (PBUH) said, "By Him in Whose Hand my life is, you either enjoin good and forbid evil, or Allah (SWT) will certainly soon send His punishment to you. Then you will make dua and it will not be accepted". ***[Trimidhi]***

Allah (SWT)'s Great Mercy

Allah (SWT)'said,

"O son of Adam (AS), as long as you call upon me and ask of me, I shall forgive you what you have done and I shall not mind.
O son of Adam (AS), were your sins to reach the clouds of the sky and were you then to ask forgiveness of me, I would forgive you.
O son of Adam (AS), were you to come to me with sins as great as the earth and were you then to face me, ascribing no partner to me, I will bring you forgiveness as great as it." [***Trimidhi]***